ENTER THE DRAGON

The Complete Strength & Health Guide

By Delan Chan

Welcome To The Program!

My name is Delan. Your very own trainer and guide.

I specialize in general strength training, mobility, and rehab, with a combination of a simple, strategic, and effective evidence-based approach, while also balanced with the hard-earned wisdom from the iron-elders on the barbell council to help you build strength, muscle, increase mobility and performance, lose fat, fix injuries, etc.

In short, I help people become muscle mommies, father figures, glorious grandparents, Greek god statues, and everything in between by cutting out the noise, simplifying the process, and making it downright enjoyable along the way.

Welcome to practically the only guide you'll need to get you started on your personal fitness journey and education. This guide is not only a program that shows you a specific workout, but is an entire A-Z guide to maximize your health, build the body you want, and enjoy yourself in the process, so you can be the person you want to be. In short, this is a full transformation guide that doesn't demand world-shattering, cataclysmic change on your end, but is adaptable to fit your personal needs.

This guide will teach you the four main steps that will maximize your physical health, provide a protocol to address your injuries, and a resistance training program that will show you key principles on how to train your body for your specific goals.

I see many people either coming into the gym and just doing random things that "feel hard" without a plan, hoping it is enough to cause change, or people who overthink what they must do, but never actually apply themselves to intentionally and intelligently applied work hard. To make progress, you must work hard AND smart. You need intentionality with intensity and intelligence.

Look, I like you all. But my goal for this guide is to provide the base education for you, so that you will not need me or this guide later on. You will become the guide for a new generation! I want this basic knowledge to drill down into you, so that you can think properly, and also to develop a powerful, strong intuition about how to make the best decisions for your health and physique. My goal is to lay down the key PRINCIPLES to help you develop the proper mindset to co-create with you the best possible and most effective protocol to get you to your ideal health, body, and performance, whether that be getting leaner, "toning", building a proportionate amount of muscle, becoming more athletic, etc.

That's why I'm using the word "guide." I'm not TELLING you what to do. I'm giving you tools so that you can individualize it to yourself and make it work FOR YOU. Don't try to become like anyone else by doing EXACTLY what they do. Don't copy anyone else. Certainly don't be like me. One of me is enough, and the competition is brutal. Learn from others and take what works, but subtract what doesn't, apply yourself, and simplify everything so you can continually make progress towards being the best you possible. Once you individualize and embody simple key

principles for yourself and simplify them to yourself, everything becomes automatic and absolutely effortless.

Simplicity is brilliance. Even Einstein said that a simple answer is an answer from God. The best things in life are simple and adaptable. This guide is written to simplify your health and fitness journey and make it adaptable for your unique goals and needs.

What's On The Menu For You?

1. The Health Guide — The health guide will give you the basic building blocks you need to know and practice to maximize your... well... health. This is important, especially if you want to look good, because your looks and whatever your fitness goals are are tied to your health. Being lean, strong, mobile, and muscular relative to your unique genetics is the ultimate sign that you are as healthy as possible, which manifests itself in how you appear.

Think about it: in Greek philosophy, there are the three transcendentals: truth, goodness, and beauty. Beauty is connected to the health of something, and the health of something is connected to its life or quality. The quality of an apple is connected to the quality of its appearance. The quality of the freshness of a steak is tied to its appearance, etc. Therefore, the unique expression of your appearance is tied to your health.

The basic building blocks for physical health and fitness are cardio/activity levels, nutrition, sleep, and ultimately, resistance training. We will address how to maximize these to become the healthiest you can be, with simple diet guidelines that you can adapt to yourself, a training program that can give you amazing results two days out of the week, and more!

2. The Rehab Guide — At some point in our lives, most of us have had an injury. Boy, do they suck. However, most injuries are not forever and can be dealt with properly if you have the proper perspective, principles, and protocol to deal with them, whatever the nature of the injury might be. This guide will give you the foundational knowledge you need to address your pain and injuries and prevent them.

3. The Program Guide — Now this is where the rubber hits the road. Resistance training is the heart of any kind of program designed to transform your health and body. This guide will teach you how to start, what to do, how to progress, when to progress, exercises, sets, reps, and some program templates where you can plug and play into a program that is tailored to you.

4. The Athlete Guide — Maybe you're an athlete and you need a guide to help you develop that "x" factor, or you simply like the idea of becoming more athletic and "functional." This guide will help you understand the basic mechanics of what athleticism is, the quality that is the "x" factor of athleticism, and how to get it.

Final Thoughts

Here's the thing: I don't only want to get you to look and feel your best so you can snap a few photos and reminisce about "that one time" you looked your best. I want you to be able to sustain it. I want you to watch yourself crush the goals that you set for yourself, to watch your health, body, and performance transform before your very own eyes, so that you can internalize it, use it across the rest of your life, and feel like a brand new person.

By doing so, you will establish a new "set point" for yourself, in which you will have new expectations for yourself. Expectations to be lean, strong, and competent in skillfully moving your body, eating drop-dead delicious foods that are both healthy and designed to keep you lean, and always making continual upward progress in your health to be the best that you can be.

Establishing these newly internalized expectations for yourself will make living and maintaining a healthy lifestyle effortless for you, because you will know how good it feels to be your best and healthiest self, how good it feels to make progress, and how downright enjoyable it is to do it and turn it into a habit.

This guide has a lot of information, and I'm not a school teacher, so I'm not going to test you on anything. Read as you need, and feel free to treat this as a reference guide by skimming.

Please enjoy yourself. I know you will!

Grace and peace.

PART I

The Why

Philosophy and principles — why any of this matters

Why Weight-Training is Superior to All Forms of Training

You might have noticed my love and attention to the importance of resistance training, and for good reason! Listen, I get that it may sound too good to be true... but it is true! Resistance training is the closest thing you can get to a miracle drug in a bottle. It is the best longevity and life quality hack possible. It can be a bit difficult for some, but it certainly looks cool when you are doing it, and it is absurdly fun.

That may sound like nonsense, but truthfully speaking, strength training is so rewarding that it is almost like a religious experience. In fact, one observation that I have made is that those who do not resistance train tend to downplay it, for whatever reason, the effects and benefits of it, as if to convince themselves that they're not missing out on much. Those who do it consistently sing its praises with the utmost enthusiasm. You see many people beginning to revolve their lives around it after falling in love with it and swearing by it, and almost arguing about it as if it were a doctrine. This is not to turn you off, but to show you how powerful and potentially addictively fun it is to do!

Look, I certainly train for the benefits, of course. But the truth is, I do it for entertainment as well! It is simply fun! I love to turn up the juice and put my pent-up oomph into something.

Now, there are some people who think that lifting weights isn't fun, and fair enough. However, I can't help but notice that these same people are the ones who look the same year after year, lift the same weights, with the same slow tempo, while looking at their phone while doing leg extensions. Frankly, I would be bored too if I lacked any intensity as well. I mean, that is less than the intensity of a normal warm-up!

If you can lift weights with a facial expression in a combination of dignified and constipated, while looking bored, you are not lifting with nearly enough effort to see great results or to have fun. I mean, just because you bit your bottom lip and opened your eyes slightly doesn't mean you trained intensely. The pain and pleasure structures of the brain are built right next to each other, so to derive satisfaction from your workout, you must push yourself to struggle a little bit.

Also, besides having quality interpersonal relationships with friends and family, a consistent spiritual practice, and finding your unique contribution to building value and impacting the world around you, exercise is probably the best and most important thing you can do to improve your life, with weight training at the top of the list. In fact, exercise can be helpful in boosting and improving all of the above by giving you more energy to do those things well, and making you more overall effective in whatever you engage in.

Just so we are clear: all forms of exercise have their place, and your preferences matter. The thing is, any physical activity is better than no activity. You should have fun while moving your body. They all have value. However, that does not mean that there isn't a

pecking order. I don't know what that pecking order is. All I know is that weight training is the granddaddy of them all. Other exercise styles will help with some of the benefits listed below, but resistance training will provide the whole package.

Pavel Tsatouline says that strength is the mother quality of all physical qualities. Without strength, no other physical quality can exist. Once you see the list of benefits below, and more importantly, once you experience them for yourself like everyone else who has experienced them after starting weight training, you will know why. Without strength, there is no muscle, endurance, stability, mobility, athleticism, rehabilitation of injuries, etc.

Another thing: Dr. Gabrielle Lyons, who wrote Forever Strong, asserts that obesity isn't necessarily the primary issue in poor health, but rather a lack of quality muscle, which leads to impaired metabolic function.

On the practical side, there are an infinite number of ways to customize your workouts to your personal enjoyment, with various kinds of intensity, effort, movements, and modalities. Of course, the best methods of resistance training are the simplest, and they revolve around barbells, dumbbells, bodyweight movements, cables, and so on. Also, it doesn't take that much time for you to experience the benefits! An hour of resistance training PER WEEK is enough to get many of the benefits. 2-4 hours per week will practically guarantee all of them.

Resistance training is beneficial for everyone, for all ages, for both sexes (there is also no "female-specific" training styles of strength training; strength training is not "training for men," but training for a human being) and for all cases, regardless of physical health, mental health, intellectual health, performance and athleticism, entertainment, rehabilitation, self-image, confidence, independence, longevity, hormonal balance, etc. Anyone can and should do it to be as healthy as possible and to be as effective in life as possible.

Full transparency: I used AI for the first time for this portion of the guide because the many benefits of resistance training were way too much to count, so I summoned the power of AI with bullet points to assist me in this instance.

Comprehensive Health Benefits of Weight Training

Musculoskeletal System

- You look better
  - Look up before and after photos of people
    - Explanation: beauty is a physical sign of health and life (vitality)
    - Ex: The health of an apple is in its "beautiful" appearance

        - The health of an animal is in its appearance
        - In the same way, the health of a person is revealed in his/her appearance (the quality of muscle and strength, total fat mass, overall bodily performance and fitness, better metabolism, gut health, etc.)
        - In other words, a good-looking body is a strong, good performing, and well functioning body
    - Often, you will see a development and revealing of stronger facial structures, leading to a better-looking face
    - This can also come from neck training and training proper tongue posture
    - You can eat more and simultaneously stay leaner
    - In the gym, aesthetic/beauty standards are tied to strength standards
        - i.e. getting stronger will help you look better, by building quality muscle that shapes your body and proportions
- Increased muscle mass and strength
- Increased explosive, athletic, and "functional" strength
- Increased muscular endurance
- Enhanced bone mineral density (stronger bones)
- Improved joint stability and mobility (stronger and mobile joints)
- Stronger ligaments and tendons
- Reduced risk and reversal of osteoporosis
- Better posture and spinal alignment
- Enhanced movement patterns (learning how to use your body)
- Injury prevention and post-injury rehabilitation

Metabolic Health

- Improves gut health and inflammation
- Better body composition (increased lean mass, reduced fat mass)
    - Increased resting metabolic rate (supports long-term fat loss, which alone enhances your health)
- Improved insulin sensitivity and glucose metabolism (good for type 2 diabetes)
- Enhanced fat oxidation capacity
- Elevated post-exercise oxygen consumption (EPOC)
- Improved lipid profiles (cholesterol and triglycerides)
- Enhanced mitochondrial function (stronger bodily cells and increased energy production)

Cardiovascular System

- Overall healthier heart
- Reduced blood pressure
- Improved cardiac output efficiency
- Enhanced peripheral circulation
- Reduced risk of cardiovascular disease
- Improves cardiovascular disease
- Improved vascular function and elasticity

Neurological Benefits

- Muscles, bones, and nerves are interconnected
  - Therefore, training your muscles also has a huge effect on bones and the nervous system as a whole
- Enhanced motor unit recruitment (strength as a skill)
- Improved neuromuscular coordination (movement skill)
- Better balance and proprioception
- Increased neurogenesis and neuroplasticity (new brain cells and changing brain makeup)
  - Increases BDNF (brain-derived neurotrophic factor)
- Increased cognitive function and memory
- Enhanced executive function
- Reduced risk of neurodegenerative diseases
  - Shows improvements in the brain linked to Alzheimer's and dementia
- Improved reaction time

Mental Health & Psychological

- A new study shows that exercise is 1.5x more effective than talk therapy and medication for common forms of depression and anxiety!
  - Enhanced mood regulation
- Enhanced self-esteem and body image
  - Improves emotional eating and relationship to food
  - Improves eating disorders
- Improved stress resilience
  - Reduced perceived stress levels
  - In fact, it changes your relationship with stress and challenges altogether!
  - Pain bothers you less, and you experience less pain
- Better sleep quality
  - Reduced time to fall asleep
- Increased confidence, self-efficacy, and independence
- There is a form of psychotherapy that focuses on the body called bioenergetics

Hormonal System

- Increased growth hormone production
- Better skin (from a better gut)
- Enhanced testosterone levels (in appropriate ranges)
- Increased libido and sexual health
  - Better erectile quality
  - Enhances blood circulation
- Improved insulin function
- Better cortisol regulation
- Enhanced thyroid function
- Improved leptin sensitivity

Aging & Longevity

- Reduced sarcopenia (age-related muscle loss)
- Maintained functional independence
- Enhanced quality of life in older adults
- Reduced fall risk
- Improved activities of daily living
- Increased lifespan potential
- Faster injury recovery time

Performance & Functional

- Enhanced athletic performance
  - Improved power output and explosiveness
  - Better endurance and work capacity
- Improved movement efficiency
- Greater physical resilience
  - Faster injury recovery

Disease Prevention & Management

- Reduced risk and reversal of type 2 diabetes
- Lower cancer risk by 40% (certain types)
- Improved arthritis symptoms
- Better chronic pain management
- Enhanced immune system function
- Reduced inflammation

Specialized Populations

- Improved pregnancy outcomes and recovery
- Rehabilitation from injuries (by definition, this is what physical therapy is)
  - Better management and physical healing of chronic conditions
- Support for healthy development in youth
- Maintained independence, longevity, and quality of life in elderly populations

Why Weight Training is Superior to Other Forms of Exercise

Unique Training Advantages

- Only exercise allowing precise, measurable progression
- Infinitely customizable to individual needs and limitations (i.e., scalable to all levels)

- Compound movements train multiple systems simultaneously (efficient)
- Can isolate specific muscles or correct movement dysfunctions

Superior Body Composition Results

- Most effective method for building lean muscle mass
- The highest metabolic impact in the long-term
- Maintains muscle during fat loss better than anything
- More effective than anything for body composition changes

Unmatched Health Benefits

- Superior bone density improvements compared to any modality
- The only exercise that effectively prevents age-related muscle loss (sarcopenia)
- Strengthens connective tissues and prevents injuries better than other modalities
- Optimizes hormonal environment (growth hormone, testosterone)

Functional and Performance Superiority

- Builds real-world applicable strength patterns
- Enhances general performance in all other activities and sports
- Improves daily living activities more than any modality
- Creates greater neurological adaptations and motor control

Practical Excellence

- Maximum results with 2-3 sessions per week
  - 2-4 hours per week
  - Even 8-10 hours per week is REALLY pushing it for professional competitors
- Weather-independent and minimal space requirements
- Provides cardiovascular benefits without joint stress or overuse injuries
- Clear, measurable goals that build confidence and motivation

Injury Recovery & Rehabilitation

- Accelerated tissue healing through increased blood flow
  - Especially for joints that are otherwise not very well vascularized
  - Promotes collagen synthesis and remodeling
- Gradual strength restoration and pain-free movement ability in injured tissues
- Helps provide "evidence" for your brain and nervous system to allow for gradual loading and regaining of pain-free movement ability
  - Addressing the psychological and emotional/traumatic aspect of physical injury
- Prevents muscle loss during recovery periods
- Reduces scar tissue formation and adhesions
- Facilitates return to pre-injury function levels and beyond
- Provides pain relief through endorphin release

Joint Health & Function

- Strengthens joint stability
- Enhances synovial fluid production for joint lubrication
- Reduces joint stiffness
- Corrects joint alignment issues through targeted strengthening

Movement Quality & Mechanics

- Corrects muscle imbalances that cause dysfunction that leads to pain and injury
  - Addresses compensatory movement patterns
- Trains proper movement patterns and functions
  - Enhances motor control and coordination

Mobility & Flexibility Enhancement

- Increases range of motion through strength training at end ranges
  - Improves dynamic flexibility and functional mobility
  - Promotes tissue extensibility through controlled stretching under load
  - Addresses mobility restrictions
  - Maintains mobility and flexibility longer than stretching alone
- Reduces muscle tension

Pain Management

- Reduces and FIXES chronic pain through strengthened support structures
- Decreases inflammation through improved circulation and blood flow
- Releases natural pain-relieving endorphins
- Reduces pain sensitivity through graded exposure
- Addresses mechanical pain sources through corrective strengthening

Postural Restoration

- Strengthens weakened postural muscles
- Lengthens shortened, overactive muscles
- Corrects forward head posture and rounded shoulders
- Improves spinal alignment and core stability
- Addresses anterior pelvic tilt and hip imbalances
- Restores proper thoracic spine extension

Functional Movement Restoration

- Rebuilds strength for activities of daily living
- Improves stair climbing, lifting, and carrying capacity
- Enhances balance and fall prevention
- Restores sports-specific movement patterns

- Improves gait mechanics and walking efficiency
- Facilitates return to work activities

Nervous System Recovery

- Promotes neuroplasticity and neural adaptation
- Enhances proprioceptive feedback mechanisms
- Improves motor unit recruitment patterns
- Facilitates central nervous system reorganization
- Reduces neural inhibition around injured areas
- Enhances sensorimotor integration

Circulatory & Healing Benefits

- Increases blood flow to injured and healing tissues
- Enhances lymphatic drainage and waste removal
- Promotes nutrient delivery to recovering areas
- Stimulates angiogenesis (new blood vessel formation)
- Accelerates metabolic processes in healing tissues

Psychological Rehabilitation

- Restores confidence in movement and physical ability
- Reduces fear-avoidant behaviors
- Provides a sense of control over the recovery process
  - Reduces anxiety about re-injury
- Improves body awareness and acceptance
  - Help aid in eating disorders as a type of adjunct therapy
- Enhances motivation through measurable progress

Chronic Condition Management

- Manages arthritis symptoms through joint strengthening
- Improves fibromyalgia symptoms through graded exercise
- Addresses osteoporosis through bone-loading exercises
- Manages chronic low back pain through core strengthening
- Improves multiple sclerosis symptoms through controlled resistance
- Supports Parkinson's disease management through movement training

Preventive Rehabilitation

- Identifies and addresses movement dysfunctions before injury
- Strengthens common injury sites proactively
- Improves tissue resilience and load tolerance
- Corrects biomechanical risk factors
- Enhances recovery capacity between activities

- Builds movement reserves for unexpected demands

Age-Related Mobility Maintenance

- Combats sarcopenia and maintains muscle mass
- Preserves bone density and reduces fracture risk
- Maintains balance and coordination
- Preserves functional independence
- Reduces fall risk through improved strength and stability
- Maintains cognitive function
  - Helps fight Alzheimer's and dementia

PART II

The How

Strategy, method, and execution

How to Eat, Drink, and Be Merry For Tomorrow We Lift

The key to ultimate health comes down to a few things: healthy relationships, a consistent spiritual practice (both of which are outside the scope of this guide), good sleep, daily activity (cardio and general movement), nutrition, and resistance training, which is arguably the most important aspect of any protocol for physical health.

Imagine yourself as the art and the artist. You are the blank canvas, the nutrition as the paint, the resistance training as the paintbrush, the cardio as the palette knife, and the sleep as the intermittent breaks for inspiration. Without the paint, you cannot apply the colors to the canvas. Without the paintbrush, you cannot create anything the way you want besides "abstract art." The palette knife allows you to refine overapplied paint, and the intermittent breaks allow for recovery for fresh inspiration.

Now, I use the art analogy intentionally because health is tied to beauty. If you want to look as good, as beautiful, as handsome, as jacked, as whatever as possible, you must become as healthy as possible, and the looks will come with it. It just so happens that becoming lean, strong, and muscular relative to your genetics is just about the best thing you can do to be your most healthy self. You have the power to influence your own body, where it goes, how it looks, and how it performs.

The formula is simple. Here it is in spelling: The key to looking good is building muscle to shape your body and being lean enough to see the shape and definition of the muscle. The key to building muscle is building strength over time. The key to being lean enough to see your muscle is a calorie deficit. Sleep enough to recover from hard sessions, and move around to be overall healthier.

Another way to say it is this: the REASON you are not in the shape you want to be in is that you are not getting stronger week to week, month to month on your key lifts, you're not eating a foundation of mostly lean protein and fiber (meat and vegetables, essentially), you're not walking 6-12k steps per day, and you're sleeping well enough to recover.

That is it! Any other detail is simply to support this formula.

To make anything work in life, you must apply HARD WORK with INTELLIGENCE. And again, simplicity is brilliance. I've simplified it for you. The "smart" work is done. Now, the ball is in your court. You need to apply yourself with diligence. If you do so, it will be hard NOT to get the results you want.

One more thing. There are two fundamental reasons why most people will not get the results that they want: lack of honesty and/or effort. In fact, it is the lack of honesty that leads to the lack of effort. This usually comes from an issue of identity, whether that is believing you don't deserve it, that it is impossible, or that you will always be... fill in the blank. Metaphysics and philosophy aside, you must be honest with your goals, even if it

feels out of reach, otherwise you will be living out someone else's goals, and you will have no true lasting motivation. From here, you will naturally apply more effort.

Take the information in this guide and internalize it into yourself by PRACTICING it. Don't just see the words in this guide, but perceive it. Don't just hear it, but understand it. Don't just listen to what I have said. Test it, practice it, and see for yourself.

Here is a guide to maximize each:

The Cardio And Daily Activity Guide

The Why (benefits)

Cardio is often seen as a form of exercise to lose fat. In fact, too much cardio can slow your metabolism, which will make it harder to lose all the weight you want. Though it can be helpful for losing fat, it is not the best thing to do to lose fat. Think of it like this: relying on cardio for fat loss is like cramming your studying for an exam the next day that you should have prepared for with little doses of study sessions, plus a few hard, focused study sessions. However, it does not mean that it is not helpful to do in any workout program. Cardio helps with...

- Heart and lung health
- Mental clarity and mood enhancement
- Helpful for burning off some extra calories
- Builds work capacity and increases energy

Cardio can be quite helpful to help lose fat, but it is not a great crutch to lean on. You can do a few sessions a week, but a more powerful weapon is N.E.A.T (non-exercise activity thermogenesis) — this basically means movements that are not exercise related. If you can increase daily movement, that will make losing fat that much easier, especially when you do decide to add in cardio to help lose a few extra pounds!

Get this: Walking 10k steps a day burns about 300-500 calories a day without increasing your hunger! That is a big deal! That deficit from your maintenance calories alone is enough to help you lose weight. Couple that with a simple and enjoyable diet and you'll lose weight easily and effortlessly.

Below are a few forms of cardio and movement you can add to your life, and some strategies to implement them:

The What (form)

- Walking
- Power walking
- Swimming

- Running
- Hiking
- Loaded carries (Strongman sandbags, sled work, farmer carries, etc.)
- Rucking
- Rowing
- Skateboarding
- Line dancing
- Gardening
- Any kind of sports (martial arts, pickleball, basketball, etc.)

The How (strategy)

Step 1: Find activities that you enjoy

- If anything, the minimum daily activity should be 8k-10k steps per day
  - This comes down to 4-5 miles per day
  - 1-2 total hours of walking daily
  - OR 30-60 minutes of running daily
- Consider the Japanese walking protocol (30 seconds fast, 30 seconds slow — alternate for 30 minutes)
- Go for short walks after each meal
- Park farther away in the parking lot
- Take the stairs
- Move around in the house more often
- Sit on the floor and squat down when playing with kids
- Play with kids more often
- Play with your pets
- Etc.

Step 2: Don't just "do" cardio, but do physical activities you like, and the cardio will take care of itself

- Make movement a lifestyle by moving more with what you are already doing, not ONLY by making it an "event"
- Try new things to expand a list of options for things you might like
- Perhaps you love running for the meditative aspect
- See above for good options for movement and cardio (form)

Key Takeaway

- Get in 8k-12k steps per day
- OR Japanese walking protocol (30 minutes total; 30 seconds fast, 30 seconds slow)
- Make movement your lifestyle
- Find an activity that is enjoyable to you that you don't think of as "exercise"

The Nutrition Guide

The Why

I've heard people say, "Nutrition is 80% of where your results come from, and training is 20%." Not true. The training is the primary mover of your results. Your nutrition "permits" and "reveals" what you have been telling your body to do. In other words, nutrition is where most of your body composition will be impacted; therefore, having your nutrition dialed in is crucial. The truth is, the only thing that matters for manipulating body composition is calories in and out, but the quality of food is what impacts your health and enjoyment along the journey.

Generally speaking, shifting from processed foods to healthier foods will result in lower calories. However, just because you eat "healthy" foods doesn't mean you'll be eating less calories and losing fat.

For example, you can lose fat by eating Twinkies, donuts, and Oreos (this was demonstrated in a study) if you maintain a calorie deficit. Although I promise you that you will likely feel terrible. Conversely, if you become a vegan but eat at a calorie surplus, you will gain weight, guaranteed; however, you'll feel better than the former group.

Depending on where you are in your fat loss journey, this means a 200-600 calorie deficit, or about 20-25% deficit. For a bulk, it is a 200-400 calorie surplus, usually on the lower side. This means that it is much simpler than people think. In my experience, the difficulty of fat loss comes primarily from social or emotional factors, or even simply the lack of tracking.

What I mean is that you can be doing a great job with your diet, but all of a sudden, one of your friends decides to have a heartbreak, and all of a sudden, everyone is out eating comfort food and beer for social support. A week's worth of good work down the drain. Thanks, pal.

The simplicity and the freedom for literally countless amounts of fat-loss/bulking strategies force you to think harder and be creative to individualize them to yourself. As well, sometimes our sleep levels, activity levels, stress, hormones, etc., can impact the amount of calories our body metabolizes, especially if you have been the type of person who jumps from diet to diet or are simply a chronic overeater, with less than ideal body composition. In other words, saying "calories in and out" is just being captain obvious. It's like saying "if you want to win more basketball games, score more points than the other team."

Luckily, this is much easier than people believe it to be, as long as you train for strength, sleep well, and know how to enjoy yourself eating "healthy" high-volume, high protein, low-calorie foods, you will easily lose fat over time — so much so that you will feel like you found a secret cheat code to lose fat effortlessly — except it isn't, since hardly anyone else in the world besides the west has to watch what they eat to stay lean.

Here is a fun fact: protein is the most satiating macronutrient out of all of them, meaning that it takes less to keep you full.

Get this: say you eat 100 grams of protein a day. This comes out to 400 calories per day, which will keep you fuller longer. As well, protein has a thermic effect of 20%. This means that it will take 80 of those 400 calories to process. Add it up in a series of weeks and months, and you'll be in a calorie deficit effortlessly.

Moral of the story: eat your protein!

And also, learn to eat fewer calories while enjoying yourself more.

Here is another fun fact: many people experience weight loss while traveling to other countries. They don't count calories. They don't watch what they eat. They simply go to town and eat whatever they want. Why? They have better food quality that does not come from boxes, cans, or packages. The higher food quality often results in better-tasting foods, with naturally lower calories.

Let me put it more simply: the practical side of weight loss lies in the principle of 'replacement' rather than 'emptiness.' Don't try to eat less of 'bad stuff,' but be filled with the things that satisfy and sustain you. Sometimes, this comes with the territory of retraining your palate.

I will teach you how to become and stay lean. Here is what the rest of the world knows that you may want to learn from:

The What

Step 1: Eliminate all (or most) processed foods from your diet (foods that are prepared beyond their natural state)

- Ex: chips, cookies, fast foods, soda, etc.
- This may be a bit challenging for some at first; however, once you begin to replace processed foods with whole foods, you will begin to lose the appetite and desire for them, thus making healthy eating effortless
- "A little here and there" goes a long way. Eliminate it completely for a short time, and watch your weight go down
- This includes protein bars, which are basically still candy bars

Step 2: Begin (or learn how) to cook and season well

- This step allows you to control the calories and nutrients going into your body while empowering you to make it tasty enough to be sustainable and effortless
- Have a pantry and fridge full of seasoning, sauces, spices, condiments, and aromatics!

Step 3: Begin eating whole single-ingredient foods, focusing primarily on protein and fiber (protein and fiber are both high volume, high satiety, and low calories, making fat loss absolutely effortless, and delicious — provided you learn how to cook and season)

- Ex: Meat
- Tofu
- Eggs and dairy
- Legumes
- Fruit and vegetables
- Greek yogurt
- Cottage cheese
- Sardines

Step 4: Replace your snacks with zero or low-calorie drinks (or eat snacks for a bulk)

- EX: black coffee, water, tea, coconut water, electrolyte powder, sparkling water, etc.
- If you are bulking, you can eat your normal meals that are at maintenance, and eat healthy, whole food snacks (cottage cheese, Greek yogurt, fruit, etc.)
- Pro tip: sip on these slowly throughout the day to curb hunger

Daily Caloric Breakdown

- Basal Metabolic Rate:
  - 60-70% calories
  - Energy burned staying alive and organs running
  - Maximized by building muscle
- Thermic effect of food:
  - 10%
  - Calories burned processing food
  - Protein burns the most calories to digest
- Exercise-related activity thermogenesis (EAT):
  - 5-10%
  - Calories burned from purposeful exercise
  - This shows that trying to lose weight primarily from exercise alone is a losing strategy
- Non-exercise activity thermogenesis (NEAT):
  - 15-30%
  - Non-structured exercise activity such as walking, chores, fidgeting, occupational movement, etc.
  - Maximized by making more movement (the "taking the stairs" approach, so to speak) a lifestyle

The How

Step 1: Pick out your "top 3" in each of these categories below that you could likely eat forever and never get tired of:

- Protein sources (chicken, steak, tofu, beans, lentils, fish, etc.)
- Vegetables
- Fruits
- Starches (bag of white rice, bag of potatoes, dry pasta, homemade bread, etc.)
- Favorites foods
- Macro-friendly restaurants (i.e., Mediterranean, Chick-fil-A, Chipotle, Asian, Mod Pizza, etc.)
- Cuisines
- Drinks
- Sweets
- Seasoning, sauces, spices, and condiments
- Styles of cooking (grilling, stir-frying, baking, etc.)
- Snacks (for bulking, or if you struggle to eat enough)

Note: Most people only eat about 5-7 meals that they rotate around for novelty. The process above is just to help you plan out the 5-7 things that you like to eat, so that you can eat more of what you enjoy and still get leaner, without eating lackluster "health foods," or going on an extreme crash diet binge cycle

- Again, figure out the 5-7 meals you love to eat, including what you love to go out to eat, and eat more of it by cooking it yourself with better whole food ingredients, and finding restaurants with foods that support your goals (i.e., Chick-fil-A, Mod Pizza, Chipotle, Mediterranean, Vietnamese, Subway, poke/sushi, other local restaurants, etc.)

Step 1.5: Prep all your foods

- Finish step 1 first
- Go shopping for things from step 1
- Cut and season your foods (raw meats and vegetables)
- Store your seasoned foods in the fridge or freezer
  - You can buy, cut, and freeze some assorted fruits as well (this can be helpful for great protein smoothies or homemade protein ice cream!)
  - Or cook them (I personally hate doing this)
- Cook when you are hungry
- Eat (duh!)
- Enjoy!

Step 2: Eat a combination of these daily

- By learning how to cook, prepping your foods and seasonings, and making your foods tasty, you can make your fat loss or muscle gain journey effortless
- Make sure it is reasonably tasty so that you will not be tempted to "cheat" on your diet because of compulsion
- Between the protein, the fiber (fruit/vegetables), and starches, eat the protein first, because protein is the most satiating, making "eating less" effortless
    - Aim for about .7-1 gram of protein for every pound of bodyweight
    - Starches are the easiest to overeat, especially if flavored well with lots of dietary fat

EX: I'll often eat fried rice (with lots of eggs for extra protein), with two chicken thighs, and half a head of well-seasoned broccoli

- With this meal, the chicken thighs and broccoli make up the majority of the plate, and I'll struggle to finish the meal
- This meal comes out to ~ 700-800 calories with 50ish grams of protein
- Remember: these meals are hard to finish, even for me!
- If I were cutting, if I ate two of these (I typically eat two meals per day), some black coffee to blunt my appetite, and some fruit for snacks or low cal ice cream at night, I would lose fat and become leaner
- If I had three of these with a few snacks, I would slowly bulk with minimal fat and no hunger
    - In fact, I would need to shift certain food choices to make it easier for me to scarf down enough food!

Step 3: Learn to make your favorite "unhealthy" foods at home with better ingredient choices — higher protein and lower calories

- Ex: homemade cookies (high protein, low calories)
- Homemade tacos
- Homemade pizza
- Homemade burgers
- Homemade Pad Thai
- Homemade cherry tomato pasta
- Protein pancakes
- Homemade ice cream
- Homemade Korean
- Homemade Cuban
- Etc.

Why This Works

I remember getting some drinks at a 7-11. As I walked up to pay, some tiny brownies caught my eye, and I was tempted to buy them too. Then I saw that it was 500 calories. I realized that if I ate 5 of these at 2,500 calories, I would slowly but surely gain weight, all the while starving the rest of the day.

Then I thought about eating apples, which are about 100 calories. At best, I could scarf down three apples, which would keep me happy, satisfied, satiated, and at an easy deficit. That is only 300 total calories! If you learn how to make good decisions by choosing and cooking foods that are healthy, nutrient-dense, and enjoyable, you can practically eat as much as you want and get the body you want without a world-shattering, cataclysmic dietary change to get there.

Step 4: You are required to have fun! Life is not for fitness, but fitness for life. Don't be afraid to eat out and enjoy yourself. Just make smarter choices and prioritize protein and fiber

- If need be, limit the amount you eat before going out by drinking a glass of water and/or a protein shake/snack before heading out to fill up your stomach with volume
- Again, choose a few restaurants that are macro-friendly

Real Life Examples: Here is a playlist of EXACTLY what I was talking about

https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PL21xpg8kaXhhAFdTpytxwzP4MQBNOIUro&si=PRbLCuwbi2JmJx_a

Pro tip: To bulk and add muscle, simply do the opposite of eating super satiating foods by switching to whole foods that are higher in calories and are easier to stuff your face with (this is relatively easy, since a good clean bulk requires no more than a 200-400 calorie surplus — leaning more towards the lower end). Assuming you're eating enough to maintain your weight, here are some foods that can help you eat an extra few calories:

- An avocado (or several)
- One PB&J
- A handful of nuts
- A glass of milk
- A protein shake
- Some eggs added to your current meals
- Some cheese
- Full-fat Greek yogurt
- Switching your primary proteins to fatty fish or red meat
- Switching from satiating starches like potatoes to pasta
- Rice with bone broth

A Guide to Portions and Measuring With Hand Sizes

Measuring is important when it comes to eating proper portions. However, measuring in an app, or using precise measures can get very old, very quickly. Luckily, there is a method that is reliably "good enough" for most people: hand measurements. It is accurate, it is quick, and practically thoughtless in comparison. It also scales to each individual. Use these measurements, and you will be eating right measure of each macro nutrient in just about every meal.

- Protein: about the size of your hand, or just the size of your palm at the very minimum (or about half the size of your plate or bowl)
- Vegetables: about the size of your fist (at least about half of your protein on your plate or bowl)
- Starches: about one cupped handful (about the same as your vegetables)
- Fats: about a thumb size (discern for yourself; personally, I cook everything with butter with about 3-5x this much)

Reverse Dieting: How to Eat More to Burn More Calories

There are some people out there who are incredibly motivated and will do anything to lose weight as quickly as possible, usually with a new and drastic diet (and often with lots and lots of cardio) to do so. These well-intended and motivated folks will often experience rapid weight loss in the beginning, but will experience a plateau. If they do lose all the weight they wanted, it is typically followed by a quick regaining of weight — sometimes even more weight than before!

This is because extreme diets are unsustainable and also force your body to make metabolic adaptations to accommodate the dramatic restriction of calories. In other words, your body will adapt to eating fewer calories to conserve energy. In this state, it will become easier for your body to store excess calories as fat. Even worse, extreme diets can deplete your muscle mass, slowing your metabolism and making you gain more fat, as well as making you appear more overweight.

What does metabolic adaptation look like? You experience more fatigue, your hunger creeps up, and you unconsciously move less throughout the day, even down to smaller movements like tapping your foot and pacing the room. Essentially, your body makes you hungry and tired to move less and conserve energy (calories). This can come from eating too little or exercising too much, or both.

If you have been the type of person who undereats and is still unhappy with where your weight is, there is hope. It is called reverse dieting.

Instead of dieting harder and smashing your head against a brick wall, follow all the guidelines above. But instead of lowering your calories, you'll want to add about 50-100 calories to your diet every week, while monitoring your scale, to rebuild your metabolism to lose more fat in the future, until you reach your maintenance calories or gain a few pounds on the scale, without looking any different.

Simply eat a little bit more progressively over several weeks without gaining too much weight. You'll want to do this while focusing on strength training and not doing too much cardio.

Once you are no longer tired, have crazy cravings, are hungry, and your weight is stable, go back into a calorie deficit to begin losing more fat. Again, follow the principles above to do this well.

Here is a podcast to explain it: https://youtu.be/GdrT1rpZAEY?si=nj4S3BcsZsRRkgx8

Why We Overeat

We all gain or lose weight depending on whether we are in a calorie surplus or deficit, plain and simple. Of course, genetics, hormones, and other factors might influence our caloric intake, but it still comes down to calories in and out, no exceptions. Because of this, if you are overweight and would like to lose weight, chances are that you overeat, or have overeaten in the past, and have maintained the weight since then. Though we can't change the past, we can change our habits now by doing what is written above. However, it is helpful to understand why we sometimes overeat to avoid doing it again. Here are a few reasons why some of us overeat:

5. You are bored (and have a lot of food options)
6. You have past experiences doing extreme diets, yo-yo diets, and/or exercise routines that are unsustainable
7. You eat a lot of processed foods
    - These foods are highly palatable, highly calorically dense, low volume, and are designed to keep you addicted to keep buying and eating in a vicious cycle
8. You did not sleep very well
    - The stress and brain fog from the lack of sleep make you hungry
9. You are stressed, depressed, lonely, anxious, or feel out of control
    - In other words, you overeat as an emotional soothing and comfort strategy
10. You don't eat mindfully
    - You just eat out of habit and don't put much thought into what you are eating

Being able to become aware of these things will empower you to know why you do what you do, and the steps to take to fix it.

Determining Maintenance Calories and Protocols

The reason I have left this for the end is that I want to give practical guidelines to help ingrain you with lifelong, sustainable, simple, and enjoyable habits that will make you and keep you healthy for a lifetime, intuitively and with flexibility, without having to count calories. However, that flexibility can sometimes lead to something that is imprecise, especially if it is your first time. Learning how to count calories helps you measure where you are at and gives you a reality check on how much or how little you have been eating.

It's kind of like if you only spend money "sometimes," but then you check your bank account to see that you've spent 65% of your budget going out to eat. Or when you decide to check how much you've been on your phone, and you see that you spend a surprising amount of hours a day on your favorite. It's the same with your diet. If you eat "cheat" meals or indulge in foods that you want to eat, because you haven't figured out an intelligent strategy to enjoy your diet yet, you'll often find that you've eaten much more than you thought you did. Because of this phenomenon, learning how to track is extremely helpful, especially if you learn how to intuitively

track your foods with your eyes with a decent estimate, without having to track your calories forever.

Here is how you can determine your maintenance:

- Take your bodyweight and multiply by 15
  - Ex: If you are 180 lbs → 180 x 15 = 2700 maintenance calories
  - Subtract by 200-400, depending on how much you want to lose
  - This is your calorie deficit
    - Stick to the lower side if you have 5-10 lbs to lose
    - Stick to the higher side if you have 10-20 lbs
- If you are overweight (20-40+ lbs to lose), take your goal bodyweight and multiply it by 15
  - If you are 220 lbs and want to be at 180 lbs → 180 x 15 = 2700
  - Subtract by 400-600
    - Stick to the lower side if you get too hungry
    - Stick to the higher side for a more aggressive cut
- For a bulk, multiply your bodyweight by 15 and add 200-400 calories
  - Always start on the lower side

TLDR

- Replace all heavily processed foods with deliciously seasoned and well-cooked foods (meat/beans + legumes/tofu, etc. + veggies + fruits)
- If losing fat, eliminate snacks (and replace with zero-calorie drinks)
- If gaining weight, eat snacks

Key Takeaway

- Key principle: Any diet goal starts with the foundation of eating primarily lean proteins (meats) and vegetables
- Step 1: Protein first as the priority of your meals
- Step 2: Veggies (and fruit) in high volumes as second priority
  - Everything else falls behind this
- Remove all heavily processed foods from your diet
- Shop for and pick whole foods that you like, and season them well
  - Prioritize protein and fiber for maximum satiety and satisfaction
- Cook... well
- Eat what you are already eating, but find or cook their higher protein, lower calorie alternatives
- Consider reverse dieting if you are overweight and undereating

The Sleep

The Why

Training is the catalyst that sends the signal in your body to adapt, whether that is growing, losing fat, or both. However, that signal is only as good as your ability to recover. Simply put, muscle growth is done in your sleep. Therefore, you must sleep as hard as you train to create the adaptations you want in your body. Without adequate sleep, you will be hungrier, more stressed, lack recovery, lack self-control, lose weight more slowly, and have less energy, leading you to make less-than-ideal decisions.

The What

Sleep 7-9 hours per night

- Take 15-30 minute naps when needed

The How

- Avoid caffeine after 2 PM
- Avoid alcohol (at least implement the 2 x 2 rule: 2 drinks max, 2 nights per week)
- Get enough physical and mental activity in the day before bed
- Sleep and wake up at the same time daily
- Process your thoughts and emotions during the day before bed (this is key!)
- Make sure your room is dark and cool
- Practice deep belly breathing in bed
- Try magnesium and ditch the melatonin
- Relax your neck, tongue, and face

The Resistance Training Guide

The Why

This is the most important part of any program. Resistance training builds metabolism to effortlessly burn fat, shapes and sculpts your body as you see fit by building strength and muscle, strengthens your heart, strengthens and builds your bones, improves athleticism, balances your hormones, improves your libido, reverses age, protects against, corrects, and fixes injuries, enhances mobility and flexibility, strengthens joints and builds connective tissue, and helps with mental clarity, cognition, mood, and mental health. Putting aside the myth of becoming a muscle-bound meathead and the fear of becoming "too big," resistance training is the closest thing to a magic pill for your health and looks.

And honestly, there is no such form of exercise protocol that is common to literally EVERY athlete, sport, military, law enforcement, etc. EXCEPT for resistance training... And for good reason!

Take the Chinese Olympic Weightlifting team, for example. They are the most dominant weightlifting team, period. They have the most gold medals out of any country. One of the key differences is clear: besides the fact that they practice the main event lifts like everyone else, they are the most muscular and athletic! How do they do that?

By building a strong base of strength (and mobility) in every place in their body! How do they do that? Old school bodybuilding style of training for strength through a variety of different movements.

Whatever your goal, whether building muscle, building strength, building muscular endurance, building speed, building power, building mobility, building coordination, building "tone", building athleticism, building your metabolism, building back from an injury, and/or simply building the body you want to build...

BUILD STRENGTH!!!

Strength is the mother quality of all physical qualities. I don't mean to build strength into the Strongest Man Alive territory. But you must become as strong as your own body and genetics will allow you to build the best body possible that is unique to you. But before we get into this, let's address a few myths surrounding resistance training:

Major Training Myths

11. Strength training makes you bulky

There is an epidemic of people who go to gyms waking up to having way too much muscle in the morning... Just kidding! That has never happened. Truth is, building muscle is a physiological adaptation that takes a lot of effort and time to build. Because of that, it is impossible to wake up accidentally too big in 3 months. Building your ideal physique takes years. If you have a low bar, it might be less than that. Either way, you don't become "bulky" without a lot of intentionality, effort, food, and let's face it, drugs. It does, however, build and sculpt your body over time, usually making you look leaner!

TLDR: "bulkiness" comes from fat or drugs; muscle makes you look ripped, lean, or toned

12. Strength training makes you slow and less flexible

If you train properly, with a focus and proper emphasis on getting stronger through a full range of motion, you will not only not lose flexibility, but you will gain it. This works because being flexible requires a certain amount of stability around your joints. If you strengthen your muscles through deeper joint angles over time, your body will give you access to deeper ranges of motion, and you will become more mobile. Don't believe me? Just look up Jujimufu and Tom Platz. Jujimufu is a big bodybuilder who can do the splits. Tom Platz is known as the bodybuilder with the biggest legs and was able to do a full pancake (Legs straddled on the floor with his chest touching the ground).

Also, strength is the basis for speed. If you are strong enough to have major control over your body, with mobility to go with it, you will have the basic building blocks for speed.

I personally used weight training to get into the splits

13. Strength training is bad for your joints

I've already touched on this one above, but just think about what physical therapy is. Besides the diagnosis, the stretches, and the massages, it is practically just modified strength training that meets you where you are at (which is all forms of strength training), with the goal of rehabilitation. Here is the truth: pain comes from weakness, leading to a lack of stability, leading to a lack of mobility, which forces your body to overcompensate, which typically leads to pain, due to excessive wear and tear over time. Strength training is the best thing you can do for your joints, bones, and injuries in general. You will learn more in my rehab guide.

14. Strength training is not as good for fat loss as cardio

There is truth to this. Cardio burns more calories than resistance training, head-to-head. However, strength training allows you to build muscle, which builds your metabolism to burn more fat over time while resting. The more muscle you have, the more calories your body will need to maintain the muscle. The less you have, the less amount of calories you will need to maintain, which means sometimes it can be easier to overeat. Remember, if you want to build muscle, you must get stronger over time. However, cardio does the opposite. Doing TOO MUCH cardio will make you lose muscle if you don't train for strength, and will adapt to your body burning so many calories at a time, by lowering your metabolism. So if you want to get leaner, "sculpt," "tone," "shape," build, whatever your body, focus on strength.

15. Strength training is not for me

Strength training is the most customizable, scalable, and tailorable form of exercise. Period. Bar-none. End of story. Because of this, it can be tailored to anyone of any age, size, sex, injury background, goal, etc. You can do exercises that are geared towards a stretch for mobility and hypertrophy (muscle gain), you can lift heavier with more intensity, you can lower the intensity and do more volume (total workload) if you don't have that "dog" mentality, you can do exercises to rehab yourself, you can take it a tad bit easier if you are older, or you can adjust the program to fit your busy or not-so-busy schedule with a hard but short and intense workout, or if you are a gym rat and want to lift for fun, you can adjust your program that allows you in daily, etc, etc. Either way, no other form of exercise will ever be as customizable as strength training, while giving you so much return for your efforts. Not even close. It is only with strength training that you can get all of the benefits that I listed above.

16. You need to go to the gym a lot to get results

Yeah.... No. Think of it like this: if you want to get a tan, you want to get the proper amount of stimulus it takes to darken your skin. Too much sun, and you burn and turn the wrong color. Too little, and you don't get the results you want. You want to work out the proper amount with intensity. Most bodybuilders, before steroids came along, trained with a full body routine 3 times a week. They had amazing results and were strong, healthy, athletic, and muscular, without looking like a freak. In fact, they looked like superheroes. Just look up the Silver Era of bodybuilding. Or look at the Longevity Muscle podcast and see how many of the best natural bodybuilders today are training 3-4 times a week. However, if you know how to program your workouts properly and you learn how to train intensely, you can train 2 times a week and still get most of the results you will ever get!

- The only thing that matters at the end of the day is if you are making steady progress in the logbook. Anything else is simply secondary

Listen to this podcast by Mind Pump to learn more:
https://youtu.be/uXsNa5UYXIA?si=sfj5eweUmZwLg1mf

How does building strength build muscle?

- One word: tension. The purpose of muscle tissue is to cause contraction by causing tension.
- Therefore, the way to build muscle and strength is to apply progressive tension overload
- That is why there are many people who have built their strength and physique in many different ways, because they've caused tension through many different means...
  - More weight
  - More reps
  - More volume
  - Deeper stretch
  - Slower tempo
  - Less rest time
  - Etc.
  - **Whatever the case, tension is the underlying cause**
    - However, simply adding weight and reps overtime is the simplest, purest, and most guaranteed way to apply tension for growth overtime

The What

Lift weights at least 2x-4x/week; either full body or upper/lower

- Incorporate primarily free-weight movements (barbell and dumbbell movements)
- (Weighted) Bodyweight and calisthenic movements
- Incorporate novelty and different variations over time (not immediately in one workout)
- If you work hard enough, you will not need more than 2-3 total exercises per muscle group

- If you work hard enough, you will not need to do more than 4-12 (up to 15 for some) sets per week per muscle group
  - This comes out to about 2-6 sets per workout
  - Ex: Barbell squats 3x6-12 + Sissy Squats 2-3x 8-15; THAT'S IT!
  - Practice quality sets
- Focus on intensity and effort, and your body will tell you how much volume (total workload) to do

- Fun fact: the greatest lifters before the steroid era, who were strong, athletic, and healthy, only lifted 3x/week with full body.
  - Most of us are not elite bodybuilding competitors. Therefore, performing full-body 2x/week, with tremendous effort, will take most of us to our 90% genetic limit
  - Look up "Silver Era Bodybuilding," or Steve Reeves or Abbey Stockton, if you'd like to see an example

The How

Muscle growth is an adaptation for strength, so to grow the right amount of muscle, you'll want to add 30, 60, and up to 100+ lbs on all your key lifts in key movement patterns with good technique and in a bodybuilding rep range. Focus primarily on compound movements and other movements that are highly scalable. The "biggest bang for the buck" exercises are the compound movements based on the fundamental human movements. If you do not get stronger over time, your body will not change. Again, you must get stronger over time; otherwise, you will not see progress

- Add 20-60+ lbs to your isolation lifts (single joint movements; i.e., bicep curls, French press, Lu raises, neck curls, etc.)

Basic human movements and the main muscles worked

17. Squat - Quads, glutes, sometimes hamstrings
18. Hinge - Hamstring, glutes, lower back, upper back
19. Horizontal push - Chest, shoulder, tricep (more bias towards chest)
20. Horizontal pull - Upper back, Lats, Biceps, (more bias towards upper back)
21. Vertical push - Shoulders, triceps, sometimes upper chest (more bias toward shoulders)
22. Vertical pull - Lats, upper back, bicep (more bias toward Lats)

Getting stronger over time - quality vs. quantity

Quality (think of this as practice and mastery):

23. Range of motion (This is key! The bottom stretch is the most important aspect of any exercise; it builds more muscle, strengthens joints, and is the secret key to mobility gains)
24. Pause at the bottom

25. Control the eccentric (the lowering phase)

Quantity (simply doing more over time):

26. Weight (seek to add 30, 60, or 100+ lbs to your key lifts over time)
27. Reps
28. Sets

The Cycle of Progression

29. Add weight
30. Add Reps
31. Add sets if needed
32. 'Master the weight' (see "quality" above) once you begin lifting heavy enough to introduce momentum/body english to your movements
    - You should be lifting heavy and SAFELY enough to put a little 'oomph' into your movements
    - This is a cycle of using "heavy enough" weight to use momentum, but 'master the weight' by practicing it towards using strict form with the same weight
33. Rinse and repeat

Realistic Rate of Progression

- Beginner: able to add weight 5-10lbs and 1-2 reps every 1-2 weeks
  - Can use linear progression
- Intermediate: able to add weight 5-10lbs or 1-2 reps every 3-5 weeks
  - Can use double/dynamic double progression
- Advanced: every 6-8 weeks
  - Can use triple progression
- Note: see spreadsheet to understand single/double/or triple progression
- This is not a hard and fast rule, but a simplification of what tends to happen. Always do your best, as it is your effort to progress that counts

Some ways to know you are training hard enough (How close to failure?)

- Change of facial expression or color
- Slowing of the movement pattern
- Inability to speak
- Difficulty at the sticking point
  - As well as shaking and/or squirming
- Involuntary guttural noises (not voluntary shouting)
- "Cluster singles" towards the end of the set
  - Resetting for every rep towards the end,
  - The need for a few deep breaths

    - Real hard training makes you think only one rep ahead, without back-to-back reps (the inability to think about doing more than 1 rep, but doing it anyway)
    - Every exercise/rep feels like a full-body exercise (Ex: you tighten your entire body to squeeze out another curl --- this example shows that even an isolation exercise should feel this hard!)
- Losing 3+ reps in the subsequent sets
- Inability to perform another rep (muscular failure)
- Low-grade anxiety before the next set (stalling and the need to convince yourself to do the next set)
    - This forces you to teach yourself to still your mind and brace your body to push yourself with FOCUS
- Muscle irradiation
    - Your ENTIRE body gets stiff and tight to make BIG weights
    - I personally call this "high blood pressure intensity"

Superpower Tip: Get a training partner (or, if need be, a trainer)! It's often hard to know, or is scary to push yourself when you are by yourself, especially if you have gymtimidation. Find someone who is as motivated as you, and push each other!

Purpose of Technique

- Not for the Technique itself
    - Technique allows for the facilitation of practicing high-effort and quality sets
- Fundamentally, to learn to focus and move through pain and chaos with poise and concentration
    - This is the case because maximally heavy weights will push you to form breakdown — therefore, you must have the skill to still your mind within the chaos of your pain, and correct your technique, while maintaining the tension on your target muscle
- Technique allows movements to be safe enough to push close to failure, where actual growth occurs
    - To stress the muscle as much as possible to induce the most amount of adaptations as possible
- To maximize and milk out as much as possible from the movement
    - To allow for the maximum effective and efficient use of muscles to grow in strength or muscle
- To push yourself without thinking about anything else
    - When genuinely pushing yourself, you'll have a harder time focusing on many things at the same time
- TLDR
    - Practicing safe sets should LEAD to hard sets
    - To work hard without getting snapped, crackled, or popped
    - Assuming you are actually training hard, you never need more than 2-3 (and 3 is a stretch!) exercises per muscle in a single workout
        - If you train truly hard, less is more
    - Know when it is appropriate to be more strict and when to allow body english
    - Good technique = relatively strict, full ROM (deep stretched) and heavy

    - the cross between deepest possible stretch and heaviest possible weight, without too much body english

Pro Tip: Always log your training!!! This is key to making consistent progress. Track...

- Exercises
- Sets
- Reps
- Weight
- Notes on technique
- RPE or difficulty (how hard did it feel on a scale of 1-10?)

PART III

The What

What to do — exercises, movements, technique, and programming

Major Training Truths

34. Extraordinary results come from consistent excellence (which is the combination of high standards, expectations, and absolutely tremendous effort that stems from realistically high beliefs in your potential), moving with and towards simplicity
    - (Long term) Consistent Progression is all that matters
    - 1-5 years for good results; 5-10 years for extraordinary results
35. The human body is highly adaptive, responsive, and ANTIFRAGILE (it can take a beating, recover, and adapt)
36. ALWAYS track your training and have a GOAL coming into the gym and BEAT your log book
    - Come in with a goal of 5 more pounds, one more rep, more quality technique, etc.
37. Training is more of an art than a science, so learn how to simplify and individualize your training over time for maximum results
38. There's always more within you than you are comfortable enough to believe (willpower, commitment, and desire) — if you saw your best self, they would likely scare you!
39. Exercise width vs. Depth
    - Stop trying to do every new and novel exercise known to man
    - Instead, find 3-5 exercises you like and get strong at those through a full ROM
    - For each workout, you will not need more than 2 exercises for each muscle, 3 at most
        - Oftentimes, 1-2 exercises within a workout can be enough if taken to 1-2 top sets to failure
40. Skill development requires more volume and frequency with less intensity
    - Development of raw attributes takes intensity and focus with less frequency and volume
41. The mechanism of adaptation is NOT about getting TIRED, but building STRENGTH
42. The only exercises that work:
    - The basics and fundamentals
        - Its derivatives and variations
        - Any other exercises that are measurable and scalable towards your specific goal
        - TikTok will likely lead you astray
43. Breaking plateaus:
    - Three main reasons for plateaus:
        - Not training hard enough or with enough effort
        - Training too much (too much volume or frequency)
        - You are on autopilot and are not intentional each time you step into the gym
    - Key Principle: stimulus vs. Fatigue
        - If you come in feeling fresh each workout, like you can do more, DO MORE!
        - More weight, more reps, more frequency, more effort, etc.
        - If you feel beat up, sore, grindy, sluggish, and demotivated each time, DO LESS!
        - Less weight, less sets, less frequency, etc.
        - Don't try to get good/strong/big at too many things at a time!
        - Pick 2-3 things AT MOST to focus on at one time
        - Rinse and repeat with different/new goals

        - You must be able to SACRIFICE some goals temporarily to achieve your main goals
    - Key Principle: sustainability
        - Ask yourself: could I do this forever?
        - If not, get curious and tweak it, keep going for a little while, or learn to deal with it
        - Make fitness fun
        - Start with the absolute minimum effective dose for maximum effect before increasing

Programming is simply a way to organize, prioritize, and safeguard these principles. If one can keep these principles in mind during their own training, an organized program is not required.

"I'm already pretty strong, but my physique isn't where I want it to be"

- A few reasons why you may be strong but don't look the way you want
    - Your strength standards are too low
    - Your physique standards may be too high
    - You short-circuited your technique, while being in a rush to meet certain standards, and need to fix your technique
        - See the purpose of technique above

Picking a program (and how to make it work)

- Find (or create) one you KNOW you can stick to long term and ENJOY
    - Ask yourself:
        - What are your genuine goals?
        - What are your practical constraints? (Time, job, family, stress, etc.)
        - What are your preferences?
- GET STRONGER OVERTIME
    - For strength specific: in the 1-5 rep range
        - No more than 4-6 exercises per workout
        - Volume work @65-80% (6.5-8 RPE)
    - Hypertrophy specific: 5-12 rep range with DEEP ranges of motion
        - Up to 8-10 exercises (assuming it is a full-body/Upper Lower split)
- Manage fatigue vs. Stimulus (Autoregulation)
    - For details, see #9 above under "Major Training Truths"

Key Takeaway

- Lift weights 2x-4x/Week
- Lift heavy, deeply, and intensely
- Pick (or learn) 3-5 movements that you love

    - Lean towards just 3 in the beginning. More is not always more
    - Hit each body part about ~ 2x/week
    - Hit each body part with ~ 4-12 total sets/week (6-10 for most people)
        - This comes out to ~ 2-6 sets per workout for each muscle (2-4 for most people, assuming you're not doing a bro split)
        - This is also assuming you are applying monumental effort
        - More volume = less effort & vice versa
        - The application is this = you feel a little beat up or have minimal equipment, so you can back off on the effort and do more volume (sets and reps)
        - Or you don't have a dog mentality to push yourself to the limits — No worries! Do a little more work to make up for it!
        - As you get stronger and more advanced, you'll need less volume (sets)
        - Train hard enough to only have 0-2 RIR (reps in reserve)
        - **High effort, total volume, and frequency in the gym all have an inverse relationship**
- Prioritize heavy compound movements in the big six movement patterns
- GET STRONGER (add 30, 60, 100+ lbs)
- For strength specificity:
    - 1-3 RIR (reps in reserve)
    - Avoid the last rep being ultra slow and grindy
    - Prioritize smooth weight increases as frequently as possible
- For muscle-building specificity:
    - 0-2 RIR
    - Prioritize pushing close to or to failure
    - Train for various reps and range of motion (ROM) PR's (personal records), AS WELL AS weight PR's
- Get a new personal record regularly!
    - So always go into the gym with a goal and intent
    - See "getting stronger over time - quality vs. Quantity" above
    - Neglecting this step will leave progress on the table
- Learn to have fun! Taking care of your health is a privilege and should be enjoyable, not a punishment

Male vs. female differences

In terms of intensity and style of training, there should not be much of a difference in how men and women should train. There is no such thing as categorically "female training" or "male training." Strength training is human training. It does not belong to one group of people, but belongs to all, in any and every conceivable category of human beings. Men and women are more similar than they are different.

But notice that I didn't say the same, because we are not. There are individual, biological, and psychological differences that make us unique. One of them is strength potential, for example.

However, the main difference, in my experience, is the desired goal. Most men want something like a Chris Evans, Captain America physique, and most women want a healthy, lean bikini model look, or a Marilyn Monroe. Because of biology, the training shouldn't be too different, as whatever we input will naturally form into what we are built for physiologically. However, you can and should customize your focus to align with your goals. For men, if you fit this category, you'll want to put much of your focus on your shoulders, upper chest, entire back and lats, arms, abs, and then strong legs, which will automatically grow your glutes, assuming you get brutally strong at heavy hinge and squat variations.

Ladies, if you fit in the above archetype, again, it'll largely be the same as the guys, but you'll want to focus more on the lower body, place more focus on your glutes, hips, legs, calves, abs, upper back, shoulders, arms, chest, etc, in that order.

Again, the training will largely be the same for both men and women, but the focus and effort will be spread SLIGHTLY differently, and the biological differences will take care of themselves, not making women "bulky," and not making men look "feminine" with big thighs and glutes. Simply become stronger within the domain of your genuine goals, and the physique you've always wanted will actualize before your eyes.

Styles of strength to learn from

- Powerlifting — building strength and learning the SKILL of top-end strength neurologically in squat, bench, and deadlift
- Gymnastics/Calisthenics — bodyweight training; great for core strength, mobility, convenience, and overall body control; has some of the best overall movements for strength, muscle, and overall athleticism, especially if you add weight
- Bodybuilding — general strength and muscle through a variety of movements with high intensity, and is the broadest in methodology, second to CrossFit, especially if focused primarily on heavy free-weight variations and strength progressions over time
- Olympic Weightlifting — learning the skill of top-end power with highly specific competition movements; great for technical coordination, mobility, and power, especially in the posterior chain, traps, and shoulders
- Strongman — Great for getting brutally strong through a broad variety of movements; builds incredibly strong posterior chains, shoulders, hands, and work capacity through awkward movements such as sandbag carries, farmer's walks, lifting stones, etc.
- Armwrestling — The best way to train for a brutally strong grip and forearm training
- ATG style — Great for strength through length, resulting in great bodybuilding movements, while being rehabilitative, great for mobility gains, and longevity; the best supplemental system for any and every style or system of training for mobility, longevity, and rehab
- CrossFit — Contains a bit of everything above and more, and is great for being a hybrid athlete; however, it's not the best for being jacked or being as strong as possible, but it makes you well-versed in just about every athletic endeavor

PART IV

Where This Applies

Philosophy, principles, methodologies, and practical application

On Basic Biomechanics of Strength Movements

I am a big believer in free and holistic movement. By "free," I am referring to moving as naturally as possible, being in line with how your body is built, without abiding by arbitrary standards set by overly safe trainers. By "holistic," I am referring to not allowing the current limitations of your body to impact how you move long-term. For example, I think everyone should be able to squat all the way down, regardless of their goal. There is a myth that not everyone can squat down all the way; however, they are generally abiding by specific, narrow standards that do not apply to everyone. However, everyone can squat all the way down if they have trained for it and listened to their bodies on how to do it properly and individually. It might not be the most conducive for quad-specific growth or allow for the most amount of growth lifted, but it is definitely doable and worth it for long-term health and performance.

When thinking about exercise technique, there are only a few things to keep in mind:

44. The basic function of the muscle you want to work (basic biomechanics)
45. Range of motion (how deep to go)
46. Control

Why is this the case?

Simple. It is tension that your muscles respond to. Having proper technique is not only about safety, but also about applying tension properly to the target muscle by using its proper function. The purpose of technique, as I've discussed before, is simply to apply tension to the target area while staying safe and healthy, so that you can keep progressing. Again, the goal of safety is not safety, but to get to your destination in one integral piece. For example, the basic function of the bicep is the bend the elbow. Therefore, the proper way to train your biceps is to apply tension by bending your elbow with a load. Get stronger over time, and your biceps will grow.

How to make sure you're applying all of these:

47. The most basic way to make sure that you work your target muscle is this: the muscle you want to grow most is the muscle you want to stretch (or lengthen) most before you move according to its function (squeeze). You'll learn more about how certain muscles function below.

Think about it like this: everyone should squat, but everyone has different limb lengths and hip shapes. That will affect the way you squat. For some, squatting with an upright position will feel more natural, which will be conducive to the amazing development of the quads. For others who may have longer femur lengths, squatting upright will be more difficult, and they will find it easier to squat in a way that targets the muscles in the back of the body (the posterior chain — low back, glutes, hamstrings, etc.). In this instance, with the squat, the upright squatter will experience a deeper stretch in the quads at the

bottom, since his knees will be shot forward. The taller squatter will be a bit more bent over, resulting in a stretch in his posterior chain. Whatever the case, whatever muscle they tend to target, is the muscle they will feel a stretch with at the bottom, as well as the muscle they feel working as they come back to the top.

48. Go as deep as you can with the specific muscle, as if you were trying to rip or pry them apart. Back to the example of bicep curls, lower your forearms down from the top position with control, allowing the bicep to be stretched, with the feeling of the muscle being pried apart at the bottom.

49. There are two basic parts of an exercise: the concentric (the part where you lift up) and the eccentric (the lowering phase). The concentric is where you "squeeze" or shorten the muscle, while the eccentric is where you "stretch" or lengthen the muscle. Both are equally important, since both phases and positions apply tension to the muscle, which is the function of muscle tissue. To keep it simple, here is what I personally like to do: explode on every rep on the concentric (refer back to the athlete guide) and stay in control of the eccentric. By staying in control, I simply mean that you should not let gravity do all the work for you by dropping the weight. This means to move the weight up as fast and as explosively as possible, and lower the weight for 1-2 seconds max. Personally, I think spending too much time on the eccentric phase is a waste of time and lowers the potential for lifting heavy weights. However, if you are injured, or you lack heavy enough weights to apply proper tension in your muscles, or you simply hate lifting heavy weights, adding time to your eccentric phase may be beneficial.

In terms of how your body moves, think about how your muscles relate to your bones. Your bones make up the framework of your body. Your muscles move your bones, which are connected by your joints that rotate your bones in relation to one another. When you have a basic idea of how your body moves and the function of each individual part, you can have a much better idea of how to move properly to apply proper tension to the muscles you want to grow and strengthen.

Basic Human Movement Patterns

50. Squatting — quads, glutes, hamstrings, lower back
51. Hinging — hamstrings, glutes, lower back, upper back
52. Horizontal Pushing — chest, shoulders, triceps
53. Horizontal Pulling — upper back, lats, biceps
54. Vertical Pushing — shoulders, triceps
55. Vertical Pulling — lats, upper back, biceps

Body Parts and Their Basic Function

56. Shoulders
    - Raises the upper arm in front, out towards the sides, and behind
57. Upper Back (Traps, Rhomboids)

    - Controls the scapulae (shoulder blades)
        - Elevates the shoulder blades
        - Squeezes or pulls the shoulder blades down and back
58. Lats
    - Pulls the upper arm downward towards and into the torso
59. Chest
    - Moves the upper arm across the torso
60. Triceps
    - Extends or straightens the elbow
61. Biceps
    - Flexes, or bends the elbow
62. Forearms
    - Moves your fingers and palms towards or away from your inner arm, as well as rotating the palm
63. Abs
    - Flexes or bends the spine, as well as stabilizes it
64. Glutes
    - Extends the hips, stabilizes the hip, moves and rotates your thighs outwards, and "tucks" your hips in
65. Quads
    - Extends or straightens the knee
66. Hamstrings
    - Bending or flexing at the knee, as well as extending the hips
67. Calves
    - Points your toes down

Of course, there can definitely be more details to this. However, these are the most basic and elemental functions of each body part that will help you understand how they work and how to apply tension to them in your exercises.

Addressing Weaknesses/Sticking Points

When you first start lifting weights, your whole body will be a weakness. However, when you continue making progress well into your intermediate stages, you will begin to recognize where you shine, where you don't, the exercises you like, and the ones you avoid. Although this can simply be idiosyncratic and personal preference, it is also an indication of your strengths and weaknesses, in both your physique and your strength. When you approach a sticking point in an exercise, you might notice where you consistently struggle or fail during an exercise. This is unavoidable, since your body will always make the strongest muscles in your body bear most of the load, and your brain will make you avoid the exercises you suck at and make you do the ones that you enjoy, since we tend to like the things we excel at and hate the things we suck at. However, when indeed we are well into the intermediate stages, this is how we get stuck. Stay here too long, and you'll begin to believe that you are at your limit and will lose motivation and not make further progress. This is terribly unnecessary and not very fun. If you learn how

to actively address your weaknesses consistently, so that you can make your true strengths shine, you will continue making progress, have more longevity in the gym, have more fun, and develop a well rounded physique. Here are a few ways to identify your weaknesses and how to address them:

Identifying Weaknesses

68. Where do you look weaker and smaller in the mirror?
69. Where do you tend to fail in your lifts?
70. What lifts do you tend to avoid or are bad at?
71. What muscle groups do you tend to favor and which ones do you tend to neglect?

Solutions

72. Principle: if you tend to fail at the bottom (the stretched position), train the musculature in the torso; if you tend to fail near the middle or end, train the limbs
    - Example: if on the bench press, you fail off the chest — train the chest; if you fail towards the top — train the triceps
73. Train the muscles you know you are avoiding and/or know you are weak or small
74. Train the exercises you are weak at, bad at, or are avoiding for ego purposes
75. Switch your variations that address your weaknesses
    - Example: if you are weak on your lockout on bench press — train close grip bench; if you are weak off your chest — train Larsen presses

Basic Exercise Technique Cues

How to Brace (proper breathing while lifting heavy)

Think about a soda can: a full and pressurized soda can is less likely to be crushed while being stepped on than an empty or opened soda can. Be the former. But how? It is called BRACING

- With whatever heavy movement you perform, think about taking a big, deep BELLY breath, creating pressure in your stomach, before going underwater
- DO NOT breathe out until you get back to the resting position
- This allows you to stay tight, protect your spine, and lift heavier safely
- Rinse and repeat

Squat

- Step 1: Stand about hip to shoulder width, with your toes pointed out (as much as you need to go all the way down as low as possible)
- Step 2: Brace your core, with your ribs down like you are about to be punched in the stomach, before you perform your first rep
- DO NOT breathe out until you get back to the top

- Step 3: Drop down as naturally as possible, with your hips and knees bending about the same time, like you are taking a dump in the woods while camping, while staying as upright as possible
- Look up how Olympic weightlifters squat; regardless of your limb lengths, everyone can squat like this
- Do not allow too much rounding of the lower back at the bottom
- However, if there is a lot of rounding, that may be a signal to work on the mobility of your hips and/or ankles
- Step 4: Once you reach the bottom, drive through your midfoot, and explode out of the bottom
- Thinking about pushing your knees outward to prevent knee valgus (collapsing inward) and rising with hips first
- Step 5: Rinse and repeat

Common Mistakes:

- Standing too wide or too narrow
- Not bracing
- Knees caving in
- Exaggerating hip flexion (pushing butt back too much)
- Rising with hips first
- Not going low enough
- Rounding at the spine at the bottom when you have inadequate mobility
- Trying too hard to keep toes pointed forward

Deadlift

- Step 1: Position your mid-foot underneath the bar about hip to shoulder width, with your toes slightly pointed out
- Step 2: Grab the bar without moving the bar (this is key!)
- Step 3: Bend your leg just enough to touch the bar and push your hips back, WITHOUT (this is key!) moving the bar
- Step 4: Brace your core, and think about pushing the world away (not emotionally, just physically), driving your hips forward, keeping the bar close to your body, and dragging it up your legs
- Step 5: Lower the bar, rinse and repeat

Common mistakes:

- Bending your legs too much
- Moving the bar during the setup
- Thinking about "pulling" the bar, rather than pushing the world away
- Not keeping a tight upper back and spine
- Not keeping the bar in contact with your legs at all times

Romanian Deadlift

- Repeat the setup for the deadlift, but do not bend your legs to meet the bar

Additional tips:

- Do not allow your lower back (lumbar) to bend
- Do not extend your lower back too much (pointing your butt way into the air)
  - Your butt should go straight back, not "up and back"
- Keep your lower spine (lumbar) relatively straight, by...
  - Keeping your upper back tight and the bar in contact with your legs for the entirety of the movement
  - Without bending your lumber, think about getting your ribs down like you are bracing for being punched in the stomach
  - Drive your hips back like you are loading for a hip thrust
  - Thrust your hips forward, instead of thinking about "pulling" the bar up
  - You will know you are performing this correctly if you feel most of the tension in your glutes and hamstrings, rather than your lower back
  - Remember, it's all in the hips!

Bench Press

- Step 1: Find a comfortable grip, anywhere from shoulder width to slightly outside shoulder width
- Step 2: Before performing the movement, pack your shoulders back, like you are squeezing a pen in the middle of your back, and down into your "back pocket"
- Step 3: Lower the bar down to your chest, about nipple level, keeping your upper back tight and down
- Puff your chest up to the bar as you lower it to stretch the muscles of your chest
- Keep your elbows at about a 45-degree angle
- Drive your elbows down behind your back
- Drive your elbows, not your hands, back up
- Step 4: While driving the elbow up, think less about driving them "up" into the ceiling, and more about "meeting them in towards the middle"
- Step 5: Rinse and repeat

Leg drive while bench pressing:

- Keep your core tight
- Get your feet planted firmly, almost behind your knees
- The tightness of your lower back and the planting of your feet should result in a natural arch of the lower back
- When pushing the bar up, think about tightening your butt and extending your legs, without having your hips come off the bench, to give additional driving force into the bar

Common Mistakes:

- Flaring elbows
- Not touching your chest at the bottom

- Having a loose wrist
- Losing tightness in the upper back, shoulders shooting forward on the bench (scapula protraction), and losing lower back arch
- Not using leg drive

Overhead Press

- Step 1: Adjust your grip to be right outside of shoulder width
- Step 2: Tighten your abs and glutes to support your lower back
- Maintain a tall and upright position with your chest up
- Keep the bar tight up against your throat, almost like you are choking yourself
- Squeeze the bar as hard as you can
- Do not let your wrists be bent all the way back
- Step 3: Keep your elbows forward to prevent the bar from dropping or putting too much weight on your wrists
- Step 4: Move your head out of the way by making a "double chin"
- Step 5: Press all the way through
- Pull your head through the window, and press up as vertically as possible
- DO NOT press in front of you
- You must move your head out of the way so that the bar can move in a straight line upward
- Always keep the bar as tight and as close to your body as possible
- Step 6: Rinse and repeat

Common Mistakes:

- Grip is too wide or too narrow
- The wrists are too bent
- Too much elbow flare
- Pressing the bar forward, not in a straight line
  - Not having the proper head position while pressing
- Having the bar too far away from your body
- Not having your elbows forward
- Too much lower back arch

Row

- Step 1: Load your hips back like you are about to perform a deadlift
- Step 2: Brace your core and back
- Step 3: Grab the bar (or dumbbells) and pull explosively towards anywhere between your belly button and sternum, while driving your elbows back behind you and raising your chest up
- Think about squeezing a pencil in the middle of your back, while packing your shoulder blades down in your back pocket
- Your elbows should be about 45 degrees

- Step 4: Rinse and repeat

Common Mistakes:

- Too upright in position
- Too much weight
- Not using straps for a heavy enough weight
- Rounded back and shoulders
- Flared elbows
- Not using your back and using too much of your biceps
- Too much momentum

Pullup/Pulldown

- Step 1: Grab the bar anywhere from shoulder width to slightly outside of shoulder width
- Step 2: Sink into a deep stretch of your lats
- Step 3: Initiate by arching your upper back and puffing up your chest to the ceiling
- Step 4: Pull yourself up by driving your elbows down into either side of your hips
- Step 5: Lower yourself down with control, rinse and repeat

Common Mistakes:

- Not going all the way down
- Not getting your chin above the bar
- Too much momentum
- Allowing your shoulders to roll forward
- Using too much of your arms instead of your back
- Not prioritizing pull-ups

Why Primarily These Movements

Learning exercise technique is kind of like learning how to drive a car. You come in with your left foot on the brake and your right foot on the gas. It feels natural, but it is inefficient. Soon afterwards, your initial instincts will feel unnatural, and the proper way to drive will feel more natural. To learn exercise technique is the same process. It might feel unnatural at first, and you will feel awkward and lose strength initially, guaranteed. However, in about 3-4 weeks, your body will adjust, and you will have a new skill and intuition on how your body moves. These movements are the most basic and foundational ways that your body moves. The movement principles within will teach you how to move in other similar movements of the same category (see the "Exercise Index" below). Learning how to skillfully move properly with these movements might feel awkward at first, but then you will learn how to intuitively move properly after you have mastered these. The point of driving technique and car handling is not driving technique and car handling. It's to take you places that you want to go safely. The point of lifting weights isn't lifting technique. It's to get stronger safely, so you can build the body you've always wanted to build. So, if you learn proper technique, it should be ingrained in you that if and when you decide to try new exercises, your bodily skill and intuition

can tell you how to do it both similarly and differently, rather than exclusively relying on another person to tell you how your body is supposed to move. It is always helpful to have many advisors. But it is even harder to embody that for yourself. Therefore, learn to listen to others, but also to your own body's intuitions.

The cues above are simply a few things to help you lift as heavy as possible and as safely as possible. Everything else in between will come down to personal preference and individualization. Lastly, although it may seem complicated with so many steps, it is truly simple. Your body already knows how to move in these simple ways. You just have to retrain it. It is not rocket science, just simple movement. As long as you don't overthink it, have fun, and try new things with curiosity and an open mind, you'll learn it and master it much quicker than you might imagine.

On Biasing Towards Different Goals

I believe in simplicity. Not that I believe that details don't matter, but they often can be distractions from the big picture or give needless novelty, while giving rise to the systematization of mere personal preference or idiosyncrasies. The only details that matter are the details that make the difference in the large scheme of things. Case in point, most training goals, even if they are different, can be accomplished with similar movements. The differences in the details lay with the effort, volume, cadence, exercise variation, standard of execution, etc. For example, you can squat for different reasons, whether it be the restoration of your movements and function, for rehab, strength, or muscle growth, etc. Of course, they all overlap, but how you execute the squat will BIAS one over the other. You can focus on the bottom stretch for rehab of knees or hips, squat onto a box to scale to your ability, focus on maximal intent out of the bottom for strength, etc. Frankly, there are endless possibilities, which is why principles are superior to details, because principles guide your thinking with creativity, whereas details only come one-by-one. That is why there are plenty of healthy, strong, muscular, mobile people who have gotten there, despite their training differences.

You will learn more about how to train for different goals in later guides, but this will lay a basic foundation of understanding. The basic goal for all of them is simple: Get stronger. However, the guidelines and criteria of HOW that strength is EXPRESSED will look differently from goal to goal. Here are a few examples:

Mobility/Rehab

- Basic goal: get stronger by focusing on getting a deep stretch (not through pain, but only through a little discomfort), controlling the weight on the negative, and getting a good squeeze to facilitate rehabilitation of pain, restoration of movement, or gaining access to deeper ranges of motion (mobility)
- Effort: about a low-moderate around 6-8/10 effort level (Henceforth known as RPE)
- Tempo/Cadence: slower negative, deeper stretches, added pauses, hard contractions
- Volume: lower load, higher volumes 2-4 sets of 10-20 reps, 2-3x/week
- Execution: Focus on absolute full (and progressive) range of motion, feeling deep stretches, and contractions

Strength and Performance

- Basic goal: get stronger by frequently adding load with maximal intent
- Effort: High effort, not to failure around 6-9 RPE
- Tempo/Cadence: Control the negative enough to not go haywire, explode with maximal intent
- Volume: anywhere from 3-5 sets of 1-5, with higher frequency (2-3x per week) on primary strength/power exercises
- Execution: focus on movement quality and smoothness, not focused on muscle activation, avoiding failure

Hypertrophy (building muscle)

- Basic goal: get stronger to get bigger while accumulating tension + fatigue (going close to failure) with the primary focus on intensity
- Effort: always about 8-10/10 effort close to or all the way to failure
- Tempo/Cadence: can be slower, moderate tempo, or explosive, with a controlled negative
- Volume: anywhere from 2-4 sets of 6-15 on any given exercise
- Execution: focus on tension close to or to failure applied to the muscle, not necessarily the movement

Hybrid (my personal preference)

- Basic goal: get stronger by building a strong base of strength, muscle, and mobility through strict technical standards
- Effort: ranges from 6-10/10 effort
- Tempo/Cadence: explosive positive (concentric), controlled eccentric, optional pause
- Volume: lower-moderate volumes of 2-3 all-out sets of 3-15 on any given exercise
- Execution: balanced blend of everything above, depending on the goal/reason for the exercise

A Note on the Use of Momentum

Two types of people annoy me at the gym: the technique cyborgs who pride themselves on being "science nerds," and your peacockers who grunt, scream, and swing weights around to brag to their friend about how "strong" they are, when in reality they did not use any kind of technique, let alone proper technique. Both kinds of people are simply looking for ways to show their value in the gym. One seeks it by feigning intelligence to cover for their lackluster physicality, while the other does so by swinging as much weight around as possible, achieving nothing, so he can tell other people who do not care.

Just remember, the driving factor that grows muscle and builds strength is tension. That fact alone means that there are many ways to achieve strength and muscle, because

there are many ways to cause tension in the muscle. What remains is this: genuine effort and progressive tension overload, while applying tension towards your target muscle. Anything else is just derivations of these principles, or simply distractions that have nothing to do with progress.

What am I implying? As long as you are getting stronger while applying proper tension to your target muscles with "good enough" technique, you will do just fine. There are two types of people in the gym who are jacked: the people who are genuinely strong and jacked with incredibly strict technique, and the people who are jacked, stacked, succulent, and dense with looser technique. What I am saying is this: they both work well and are two valid modes of training for different life seasons, circumstances, and temperaments. Personally, I have found that using a bit of momentum has been more conducive to building more strength, even when I go back to using a stricter technique. Using a bit of momentum is incredibly helpful for progression by pushing past the sticking points of a movement. In fact, "perfecting technique" from loose technique is another form of progression. However, when I do not have the self-control to hold myself back, I tend to accrue more injuries. Therefore, it is a good idea to be able to switch back and forth, depending on the goal, season, or circumstance in your life, or even just your personality. This is why I always stress individualization. There are certain cues that you must stick to SO THAT you can lift heavy, safely, and with proper tension applied to the target muscle. But everything else, again, is personal preference. You will likely get more from learning wisdom, intuition, and the "art" of lifting, rather than the "science" side of things, which can be helpful, but is only a starter pack and a compass, not a set of rules to be legalistic about. Although there is a lot of thinking when it comes to movement and training, it is all just foundational and basic stuff that leads you to learn how to feel your body. In the famous words of Bruce Lee, "DON'T THINK! FEEEEEEEEEEEL!"

Exercise Index

Note: Again, don't choose everything! Just pick 2-3 movements and master them!

Exercise Types

- Stretching (Lengthening — which actually induces the most hypertrophy)
- Squeeze (Shortening)
- Mid-Range

Compounds

Horizontal push

- **Incline bench press**
- Bench press
  - Wide bench press
  - Close-grip bench press
  - Larsen Press
- **Dumbbell bench**
- **Weighted dip**
- **Weighted Push-up**
- Pin press
- Floor Press

Push-up Variations (Horizontal push)

- Standard
- Wide
- Close/Diamond
- **Rings**
- **Weighted**
- **Deficit**
- Finger Push up
- Knuckle
- Jackie Chan
- Pike
- Hindu
- **Pseudo Planche**
- Handstand
- Archer/Side to Side
- One Arm

    - One Arm Assisted
    - **One Arm Feet Elevated**
    - **One Arm Assisted Feet Elevated**
- Clap/Explosive

Dip Variations (Horizontal push)

- Dips
- Weighted Dips
- Straight bar Dips
- Feet Assisted Dips
- Jumping Dips
- Ring Dips
- Bulgarian Dips
- RTO Dips

Horizontal pull (Rows)

- **Barbell Row**
- **Dumbbell Row**
- **T-Bar Row**
- Meadows Row
- **Chest Supported Row**
- Inverted Row
    - One arm variation
- Cable Row
- One Arm Inverted Row

Vertical push

- **Overhead Press**
- **Dumbbell Overhead Press**
- Z Press
- Push Press
- **Seated Presses and Variations**
- **Behind the Neck Press**
- Bradford Press
- **Arnold Press**

Vertical pull

- **(Weighted) Pull up**
- Wide grip Pull up
- Close grip Pull up

- **Sternum Pull up**
- Chin up
- Neutral Grip Pull up
- One Arm Pull up
  - Ring assisted one arm pull-up
- Feet assisted Pull up (rings/bar)
  - One arm
- Behind the Neck Pull Up

Squat

- **Barbell Squat**
- Sumo Squat
- Box Squat
- **Front Squat**
- Zercher Squat
- Anderson Squat
- Goblet Squat
- **Platz Squat (heel elevated)**
- Hindu Squat
- Pistol Squat
- **Belt Squat**
- Good Morning to Squat

Hinge

- Deadlift
- **Back Extension**
  - **Ghetto back extensions (rack + bar)**
- **Romanian Deadlift**
- **Stiff Leg Deadlift**
- **Deficit Deadlift (SLDL, RDL, ETC.)**
- Sumo Deadlift
- Trap Bar Deadlift
  - Trap Bar RDL/SLDL
- **Good Morning**
  - **Seated Good Morning**
- Snatch Grip Deadlift

Single leg

- Pistol Squat
- Forward Lunge
- Reverse Lunge

- **Cossak Squat**
- **Bulgarian Split Squat**
- Front foot elevated split squat
- Step Up
- Walking Lunge
- **Ass to Grass Split Squat**
- Jumping Lunge
- Single Leg RDL
- Curtsy Lunge

Isolations

Biceps

- Barbell curl
- **Dumbbell Curl**
- **Preacher Curl**
- Cable Curl
- **Hammer Curl**
- Ring Curl
  - Pelican Curl
- **Incline Curl**

Triceps

- **JM Press**
- **DB JM Press/Tricep Rollouts**
- **Overhead Extension**
  - **Single Arm Overhead Extension**
- **Dips**
- **Skullcrushers/Bent arm Pullover**
- Pullover to Press
- Bar/Ring Bodyweight Extension
- **Pushdown**
  - Incline Bench Pushdown

Shoulders

- Side Raise
  - **Lateral L Raise (Bent Lateral Raise with Ext. Rotation)**
  - **Lu Raise**
  - **Incline Bench Lateral Raise**
- **Face Pull**
- **Incline internal rotation press (stretch)**

- **Decline external rotation press (stretch)**
- Cuban Press
- **Powell Raise + Incline/Leaning Powell Raise**
- **Archer pulls**
- External Rotation
- Rear Delt Fly
- Cable Reverse Crossover
- **Upright Row**
- **High Pulls**
- **Snatch Grip High Pull**
- Ring Face Pull
- **Pike Push Up**
- Leaning Lateral Raise
- Cable Lateral Raise
- **Y Raise Variations**
- Incline Front Raise

Chest

- **Dumbbell Fly**
- Cable Fly
- Ring Fly
- Push up Variations (See above)

Glutes

- **Hip Thrust**
  - Frog Pump
- Reverse Hypers
- **Back Extensions**
- Single Leg Bridges
- Clamshell
- **Bret Contreas style lying side Abductor hip thrust**
- Fire Hydrant
- AB/Adduction Machine
- Glute Kickback
- Kettlebell swings

Hamstrings

- **Machine Leg Curl**
- **Nordic Curl**
  - **Progression:**
    - **Nordic back extensions (+ Progressive ROM)**

        - **Razor curls**
        - **Progression ROM Nordics**
        - **GHD Raise**
        - **Full Nordics**
- Swiss Ball Curl
- Gliding Leg Curl
- Dumbbell Ham Curl
- Floor Slider Curl

Quads

- Leg Extension
- **Sissy Squat**
- Pendulum Sissy Squat
- Hack Squat
- Platz Hack Sissy Squat
- Leg Press
- Single Leg Press
- Butterfly Adductor pulse
- Hyperextension Adductor Raise

Traps

- **Farmers Walk**
- **Barbell Shrug**
    - **Behind the back**
- **Monkey Shrug**
- **Snatch Grip High Pull**
- One Arm Leaning Shrug
- **Upright Row**
- Face pull

Neck

- **Neck Extensions**
- **Neck Flexions**
- **Neck Bridge Var.**
- Neck Bridge Twist + Pullover
- Neck Bridge Pullover

Calves

- **Standing Calf Raise**
- Seated Calf Raise

- Knees Over Toes Calf Raise
- **Single Calf Raise**
- **Donkey Calf Raise**

Back

- **Y Raise**
- **Face Pull**

Lats

- Pullup/Pulldown variations
- **Dumbbell Pullover**
  - Cable Pullover
- Low rowing variations

Forearms

- **Add Fat Gripz to Arm/other exercises**
- **Wrist Curl**
- **Wrist Extension**
- Hammer zottman curl
- Cross Body Hammer Curl
- **Hammer Curl**
- **Reverse Curl**
- One Arm Hang

Abs

- **Sit up (flat, GHD, Decline, butterfly bench, etc.)**
- **Reverse crunch (+ leg lifts, cross bench, incline candlesticks)**
- **DRAGON Flag (One leg, tuck, eccentric, one leg eccentric, bicycle, straddle)**
- Cable Crunch
- **Hanging Leg/Knee Raise (Can Be Weighted/Banded)**
- **Around the World**
- Cable Chop
- Landmine Twist
- Side Bend
- **Ab Wheel**
- L Sit
- Hollow Body/Rock
- Side to side leg raise
- Windshield wiper
- Ring rollout

- **GHD Halo**

SO YOU'RE INJURED. WHAT NOW?

What Is Pain and Why Does It Exist?

Pain can be annoying and get in the way of everyday life. However, pain has a purpose. It is a protective response to tissue injury, signaling to proceed with care, generally speaking. However, much of our pain is psychological, whether from high stress, lack of sleep, catastrophizing, emotional associations from previous experiences, etc. This is why placebo and nocebo exist. Much of our physical existence is heavily influenced by our habitual thinking patterns, imaginations, and beliefs (seriously, look up placebo experiments on surgery for pain, steroid placebos, practicing sports in visualization, and other stories and studies on visualization).

Simply put, pain is a complicated phenomenon, stemming from a bodily/mechanical issue, a psychological component, and/or a social component (for example, loneliness can lead to higher levels of physical pain).

How Does Pain Work?

There are three types of pain: mechanical pain (often a "dull" sensation, typically from breaking, twisting, spraining, or smashing something), nerve pain (feels like a sharp, shooting, tingling, burning, etc. — like sciatica), and chronic pain that persists long-term, even when it looks like it shouldn't.

When pain happens, it often makes us go into "protective mode", creating an ongoing state of vigilance, making our body tighten to protect against further pain. This is why we sometimes lose mobility and become tight, making us not want to move, which later makes us weaker and weaker, and more afraid of injury. On top of this, the daily stress we experience, coupled with catastrophizing, partners with the pain we already experience and makes the pain persist, creating a negative feedback loop that makes pain chronic.

Put simply, pain comes from psychological factors (your thoughts and beliefs about pain), social factors, and physical factors. Physically speaking, it comes primarily from structural weaknesses (lack of strength and mobility), leading to further stress, leading to more pain, leading to movement compensation (which is why sometimes pain in your body jumps in different places; i.e., right knee hurts for a while, then your hip hurts, then your back, and all the way back to your right knee), leading to muscle imbalances, leading to bad posture, leading to more weakness, leading to further stress...

What a wretched experience I am in! Who or what will rescue me from this pain in my body?...

But Thanks Be To Modern Rehab Through Resistance Training

There are a few ways to address pain. One: General inactivity leads to further pain. So start engaging in movement. Two, develop a healthy relationship with pain by understanding that there is no such thing as "bad movements." Essentially, address your beliefs about pain. Three, you'll want to address your mental health, social relationships, diet, sleep, etc. However, that is out of the scope of this guide.

Now, you may not be able to perform certain movements currently, but that does not mean that any kind of movement is off-limits. The point of rehab is to regain pain-free movement ability and beyond, so that you can not only fix injuries, but also develop strength, stability, and mobility that allows you to protect against future injury and pain! That will often mean you will need to progress (or regress in order to progress) towards movements that make you uncomfortable.

This works because rehabilitation (and the loss of movement and mobility, for that matter) is simply an adaptation of the body to its environment. Think about it like this: if you injured your back and you spend the next year in bed, you'll never fix your back pain, because you never put any demand on it to adapt, except to adapt to lying in bed all day. In this pretend scenario, you never sent the signal to your body to adapt to a new stimulus to move towards pain-free ability and movement.

In short, this is what I am saying: You have heard it said, "use it, or lose it." But I say to you, train it, or don't gain it. This includes the adaptation that comes from rehabilitation.

Now here is the truth: resistance training is bar-none the most effective form of rehab for addressing pain and injury, full-stop, end of story. In fact, that is what physical therapy largely is. Stretching, foam rolling, manual therapy, massage, etc., are secondary at best. This is because resistance training regenerates your muscles, joints, and bones, and changes your whole body by signaling and demanding ADAPTATION. The stronger you get, the more pain-free the ability you develop, the better the response. By starting with what you can currently do, and ACTIVELY progressing over time, you can regain movement ability that you have lost due to pain and injury or build new movement ability that you have never had before, despite your age (in reality, you'll actually be reversing your age!). And yes, this also includes arthritis.

So what do you want to do? You'll want to use resistance training to build evidence and structure. You build evidence to tell your brain and nervous system that it is safe to proceed, and structure to fix the underlying weaknesses that cause the pain and tightness.

So here is a short takeaway: Begin by making movement a lifestyle, whether that be gardening, dancing, going on walks, playing sports, playing with small kids, parking far away, taking the stairs, walking around the house more often, etc., to increase blood flow and initiate healing, as well as correcting your posture while standing, walking, and sitting down.

Then address non-physical aspects, like stress management, sleep, diet, beliefs about pain (which can largely be fixed by gaining movement literacy), social relationships, etc. However, much of this can be addressed through resistance training anyway, by teaching and proving to your body that it is safe to move in certain capacities, as if you are generating buy-in to your nervous system.

Lastly, focus on getting stronger, developing basic movement skills and abilities through heavy and progressive resistance training, and a deep range of motion into a deep stretch. That's it! You don't need a 10,000-step, overly careful protocol with entry-level movements that don't make a big difference over time. You simply need to start moving and strengthening from a pain-free place to newer and newer heights of pain-free ability and movement by restoring strength and mobility over time, by signaling to your body the demand for new adaptations. You don't need to live with your pain. Simply start now, and become stronger!

Rehab is resistance training from a lower starting point with a variety of modified exercises designed to meet you at your level, to raise you back up to a new level of pain-free movement ability. Another way of thinking about it, is that rehab is a method of progressive exposure toward complete and pain-free movement through resistance training.

Rehab Protocol

Step 1: Wait for initial inflammation to subside and the injury to heal as much as possible before working on the restoration of strength and ability

Step 2: Don't stop moving, or start moving again, to encourage blood flow

Step 3: Strengthen the affected area indirectly by getting stronger in the structures around the affected area

- Ex: if you have a herniated disc, start by learning proper posture and core engagement
- Then get stronger in your glutes, your hips, your hamstrings, your core, your upper back, your feet (practically your whole body)

Step 4: Strengthen the affected area with shortened-bias exercises for:

- Easy re-entry into movement in that area
- Encourage blood flow for healing
- Build and regain basic stability and some mobility

Step 5: Build new movement ability by getting stronger through a deeper range of motion, from assisted to bodyweight to loaded, ultimately until you can do an exercise through a deep range of motion with weight

- Ex: continuing with the example above, after you strengthen areas around your back, begin training the back directly

- You might want to start with back extensions with assistance and/or a short range of motion, or even a rack pull with light weight and short range of motion
- Begin by adding a greater range of motion over time
- You can know if you can keep progressing if you INTENTIONALLY AND SLOWLY attempt to go farther down and/or add weight progressively
- Once you can get all the way down pain-free, begin adding more weight
- Continue doing the exercise until you are pain-free and have restored all of your movement ability
- Note: This is a simple example with one exercise. In reality, you could up the dose with more, if you are able to perform more pain-free

Some Notes

- Wait for the initial inflammation to subside before doing any kind of active rehab work
- Improve your daily posture and movement quality, and start moving daily
- Rehabilitation is not linear; there will be flare ups here and there
- Key Principle: Rest when you need, but DON'T stop moving
  - Motion is lotion
- Key Principle: Pain/persistent injuries are caused by bodily weakness, so structures MUST be strengthened
- Key Principle: Healing = restoration of mobility and building strength towards bodily ability (whether walking, bending, stretching, twisting, pushing, etc.)
  - **In other words, the goal is to restore basic movement ability, such as pain-free squatting, hinging, bending, pushing, pulling, etc., and/or by performing supporting exercises to make this happen**
  - Also helpful through blood flow with shorten-biased movements and exercises
  - Lengthen what's tight, strengthen what is weak
    - Strengthening through length will take care of both!
- Key Principle: Rehab is simply training towards regaining
  - *In other words, rehab is simply a form of resistance training with a more gentle start and a more disadvantaged beginning point*
- Key Principle: Regression is Progression (3 types: loaded, unloaded, i.e, bodyweight, and assisted)
- Key Principle: Use it, or lose it
- Key Principle: Train it, or don't gain it
  - Find scalable movements with full ROM (stretch to squeeze) to encourage blood flow (blood flow encourages healing); i.e., Strength and flexibility
    - **I.e., choose exercises that are INHERENTLY corrective, and build mobility, muscle, and strength**
    - Doing this allows you to build all physical qualities maximally, rather than spending extra time doing "corrective" exercises, "mobility" exercises, "strength" exercises, and "muscle" building exercises
    - Which exercises does this? See below

- Key Principle: There is no such thing as a bad exercise; only a personal lack of stability, mobility, strength, and overall skillful movement ability — which can be trained and corrected
- Key Principle: Eventually work up into exercises that are inherently disadvantaged will bulletproof the body, as long as you use lighter loads, higher reps, and reasonable volumes (behind-the-neck press/pull-ups or pulldowns, upper back rounding in deadlifts, Jefferson curls, deep good mornings and RDL's, upright rows, etc.)
  - Take the Chinese Olympic weightlifting team, for example. Weightlifting has some of the weirdest and seemingly most injurious exercises ever, like squatting all the way down, pressing behind the neck, pulling heavy weights from the floor, sometimes with a rounded back, etc.
  - Yet, out of all the barbell athletes who lift weights as their primary sport, Olympic weightlifters have the least amount of injuries, despite their "dangerous" looking exercises. They have fewer injuries than bodybuilders, powerlifters, crossfitters, strongmen, etc. And they lift incredibly heavy weights
  - Why is this the case?
    - They built up the ability to move freely in all kinds of positions, became stronger, and made "dangerous" positions just another position for themselves.
    - They utilize weirder movement variations that MOST well-intended professionals believe to be dangerous
    - This DOES NOT mean you have to become an Olympic weightlifter
    - ONLY that we can take a page out of their training to FIX and PREVENT pain and injury
  - This is the idea of anti-fragility: slowly doing movements that you were unable to before and becoming stronger, not only to resist injury and tightness, but to adapt and become even better over time
    - Everyone can do this! Resistance training with a focus on becoming stronger through a deeper range of motion over time is the key to having superhuman strength, bones, joints, mobility, muscle gain, etc.!
- Strengthen surrounding structures, as well as the directly affected area, to fully rehab an injury
- Stretching, foam rolling, massage, etc., relieves, but doesn't heal
- Use basic strength exercises that are scalable, loadable, measurable, and possibly relieving; i.e., get stronger with selective exercises
- Never work through pain and discomfort; i.e., don't force it past a 3/10 pain scale
- EX: If ankle pain, perform calves and tibialis through a full ROM and get stronger (calf raises, tib raises, sled work, etc.)
- For myofascial work, the minimum effective dose is 2 minutes +
- Unilateral Work is also HIGHLY effective for rehabilitation from pain
- Focus on building ability, from the ground up
- REMEMBER: the strength of the bone is DEPENDENT on the strength of the surrounding muscles
- Turn a stretch into an exercise (About RPE 6-7)

Key Takeaways

- Progressive overload + progressive range of motion = progressive rehabilitation into anti-fragility
- The human body was made to move freely and competently, not for "moving with clinically perfect" biomechanics, lest you risk living in chronic pain
  - Within your body is the deep and ancient ability to adapt and restore itself
  - Rehabilitation is simply another signal for your body to adapt to a new stimulus
- Focus on regaining pain-free ability, by getting stronger, from assisted to unassisted to loaded variations, from your current starting point, through a full range of motion (a progressively deeper and pain-free stretch), and ultimately a full pain-free movement, again, with load
- When in doubt, get stronger in every basic human movement and movement quality, first with muscle-shortening biased ("squeezing", not "stretched") exercise for blood flow
  - **Then progress through a full stretch**
  - Ex: sled pushing vs full deep squatting for knee pain
- The top weaknesses and/or lack of skillful movement that cause common pain:
  - Upper back and lats
  - Core (abs, obliques, and lower back)
  - Glutes, hips, and hamstrings
  - Feet and ankles
  - Note: Remember, tightness comes from weakness, and weakness causes imbalances, which cause pain. The key to pain is strength
    - **It doesn't matter if it is a bone, a muscle, a tendon, a nerve, etc. All of these structures are connected, so training to get them stronger with load-bearing exercises will address all of them!**
- Also, this protocol is not only for rehab, but ties in perfectly with a standard resistance training program in becoming bulletproof, injury-free in the long haul, and building superhuman levels of mobility, such as doing the splits if you want to.

Prehab

- Priming
- Warm Up
- Band Work
- Sled push and pull

Rehab Exercises

The three levels:

- Assisted or shortened range of motion
- Unassisted (bodyweight)
- Loaded with a full range of motion

Shoulder

- **External Rotation**
- Internal Rotation
- Powell Raise
- Lu Raises
  - Cross bench lu raise
  - Prone lu raise
- **Y Raise**
- **Incline Cuban Press**
- **Full Range High Incline Press**
- **Deep OHP**
- **Face Pull**
- Rear Delt Raise
- **Row Variations**
- **Pull-Up Variations**
- **Band Pull Aparts**
- Bridge
- Superman + Snow Angels
- **Full Deficit Push Ups**
- Cuban Press
- Swiss Bar Work
- Behind the neck press
  - Bradford Press

Back/Hips

- **Reverse Hyper**
- **Jefferson Curl**
- **RDL Variations**
  - **Single Leg**
- **Reverse Squats**
- **Leg Raises/L-Sits**
- Seated Straight Leg Raise
- **Hyperextensions**
  - **Single Leg Extensions**
- Hip Thrust
  - Single Leg
- Single leg decline sit ups (hip flexors)
- **Seated Good Mornings**
- Single leg good mornings
- Standing/Seated Pancakes
- Superman
- **Deadlifts/Rack Pulls**
- General Upper Back and Glute Work (to avoid compensation)
- Abs

- **QL Raise**
- **(Low) Windmill**
- **Side Bend (Staggered Stance)**
- Belt Squat
- Box squat
- **Sumo Squat**
- (Weighted) Elephant Walk
- **Cossak Squat**
- **Piriformis Pulse/Stretch/Deadlift**
- **Couch stretch deadlift**
- Curtsy Lunge
- **90/90 + Good Morning/Hip Thrust**
- **Glute Med Hip Thrust**
- **Frog Hip Thrust**
- **Fire Hydrant + Kick**
- **Hip Side Raise**
- Deep squat and knee pushes
- Sumo Squat to good morning (horse stance to good morning)
- Butterfly Pulses

Elbow/Wrist/Hands

- **Fat Grip Work with Basic Arm Movements**
- **Tricep Pushdown**
- Supinated Front Raise
- Skullcrusher
- Pressing Movements
- **Wrist Flexor Work**
- **Hammer Curls**
- Zottman Curls
- Grip Strengthener
- Finger Extensors
- Rice Bucket Exercises
- **Wrist Supinator and Pronator**

Knee

- **Sled Push/Pull**
- **ATG Squat**
- **Platz Squat**
- Reverse Step Up
- Step Up
- **ATG Split Squat**
- Lunge Variations

- **Hamstring Curl Variations (Nordics)**
- Pistol Squats
- Bulgarian Split Squat
- Reverse Nordic
- Sissy Squat

Ankle/Feet

- Calf Raise Variations
  - Standing
  - Seated
  - Donkey
  - Single
  - Bent Leg Against The Wall
  - Straight Leg Against The Wall
  - Slant Board Against The Wall
- Tib Raise Variations
- Sled Work
- Lunging/Split Squat Variations (any single leg variations)
- HEAVY Farmer's Walk

Head/Neck

- Neck Curl
- Neck Extension
- Wrestler Bridge
- Bench Neck Plank
- "Yes/No's"
- Above Back And Shoulder Exercises

Priming Warm-Ups and Mobility Drills

Zone 1 (Back and shoulders)

Wall Circles, Superman, Wall Presses, Halos, Prone Cobra, Handcuffs, ParaSupes, Threading the Needle, Bird Dog, Superman Rows, Band Work (pull aparts, ext. Rot., shoulder dislocates, etc.)

Zone 2 (Thoracic)

Lizard W/ Rotation, Scorpions (Supine/Prone), Cat Cow, Lying Pelvic Tilts, Up Dogs, Half Moon Lunges, Lunge Twist, Prayer Stretch, Prayer Stretch On Wall

Zone 3 (Low back and hips)

90-90 (Active + Hip Thrust), Leg Swings, Mountain Climber, Frog splits, Kneeling hip hinge, Butt Kicks, Pigeon (Hip Thrust), Single Leg Bridge, Bridge, Good Mornings, Band Walkouts, Donkey Kicks, Fire Hydrants (+ Kick)

Additional Resources

- Anything from Ben Patrick (Kneesovertoesguy)*
- Low Back Ability (YouTube)
- ATG Science (YouTube)
- E3 Rehab (YouTube)
- Gift of Injury
- Built From Broken
- Rehab Science
- MAPS Prime and Prime Pro programs
- Rebuilding Milo

The Athletic And Functional Protocol

First of all, I want to say that functional training doesn't exist, yet all training is functional. Why? Because training is simply a stimulus to tell our bodies how to adapt; therefore, all of our bodies function the way we tell them to through how to move and live. If you tell your body to become generally stronger by stressing it near exhaustion, it becomes generally bigger and stronger. If you practice top-range strength as a skill, you become more efficient with the musculature that you already have and become stronger, as you teach your nervous system how to be more efficient at using your muscles. If you move explosively, you get more explosive. If you practice a sport, you get better at said sport. So on and so forth.

Therefore, everything is functional, including and especially old-school natural bodybuilding that is focused on strength progressions over time. There is nothing more functional than simply getting stronger in the basic human movements that we all use daily: pushing, pulling, squatting, lunging, hinging, and some other even more basic movements like curls and such. Let's be honest, most of us are not full-time athletes. The most "functional" we need to be is having the ability to take one trip of holding all the grocery bags from the car to the front door, and curling them onto the counter. For some of us, that might be going up a flight or two of stairs. "Functional training" is just as much of a fantasy, and equally as "functional," as training to look good, because you are training for a cool moment of athletic or functional display that will likely never happen, unless you are an athlete. However, that does not mean that it isn't fun to do, nor is it not worthwhile, or just downright cool.

Let me tell you something I absolutely hate. I am both a martial artist and I love to lift heavy weights, yet I often see dumb videos online titled, "Small martial artist beats big bodybuilder," somehow implying that muscles don't matter, and it's all "show." First of all, muscle is a physiological adaptation to strength demands. There is no such thing as "show muscle" that doesn't work. That violates simple biology. No strength gains, no new muscle. No muscle, no strength potential.

Secondly, of course, a skilled fighter would win against an unskilled fighter. You mean to tell me that someone who practices their craft is actually better than someone who doesn't? What a novel idea. Imagine if you threw Michael Jordan on his first day of hockey into a game; he would get smashed to pieces. Or if you threw Michael Phelps in a football game. Let me tell you, no amount of elite swimming will save you from an angry 300 lb linebacker. Or throw Mike Tyson in a tennis match (apparently, the prerequisite of being an elite athlete is your parents naming you "Mike" — sorry, ladies). Let me tell you, his killer left hooks will not make him automatically good at hitting balls with a racket.

The point is this: "functionality" is specific to how you want to function, plain and simple. If your function is to run around with great feet and shoot hoops in a basket, you have to run around and shoot hoops in a basket. If you want to become an amazing pickleball player, you have to play more pickleball. If you want to be good at parkour, you have to do parkour. If you want to be good at crawling around on the ground like you're a bear,

then crawl around like a bear. If you want to become a great wrestler, you have to.... Well, wrestle! You're smart, so you get the point.

In other words, if you want to get good at something, you have to do that thing.

However, when people say they want to be more "functional," they generally mean that they want that "x" factor that is common to the most impressive athletes. There are two main components to any athletic endeavor. There are the skills that are specific to the sport or "function," then there are the raw and basic attributes that make those skills come alive with more power, effectiveness, and an overall "oomph" to your bodily movements.

This is what most people mean when they say they want to be "functional." We will be focusing on building these attributes that contribute to overall athleticism. When you are overall more athletic, you can learn new physical skills much quicker. Just look at the behind-the-scenes of both Karate Kid (the original 1984 one) and Cobra Kai. These kids all learned karate on the set to perform in the movie, but the stunts in the original Karate Kid were much more believable. Why? I believe it was because they were more athletic.

So, what is the key to athleticism? There are a few key attributes for athleticism, but I believe the most basic and important one of them all is strength. As Pavel Tsatsouline said, who was the physical training instructor for the former Soviet Union, "Strength is the mother quality of all qualities." Specifically, you want to build relative strength, which is how strong you are compared to your bodyweight. For example, a 4'11" 105 lb girl who can bench press 200 lbs is more impressive than a grown 200 lb man who can bench 200 lbs. In this scenario, her relative strength is higher than the grown man's. The weight is the same, but their potential is not. So if they both were grapplers, the smaller 105 lb girl would be leagues above in her division, whereas the 200 lb man would be average at best in his division.

When you are strong relative to your bodyweight, you have much more control and command over your movements, and therefore can help develop physical abilities and skills much quicker than someone who does not have the strength and control over their body. This is because having high relative strength makes you more explosive. Now, explosiveness is a combination of relative strength and speed. When you are much more explosive, you will be much better at running, jumping, kicking, turning, throwing, cutting angles, or whatever.

The way to do this is simple. A good athletic program will look eerily similar to any good basic strength program focused on key compound lifts, but with a few tweaks. Primarily, to get strong through an extended range of motion, with lots of (weighted) bodyweight movements to increase proprioception and whole body coordination, while doing them very quickly. Doing things fast will make you faster. This will give you 80% of your athletic and "functional" fitness. Other things will be to add jumps, sprints, and optionally Olympic lifting variations and soft acrobatic movements. Below are the methods and strategies to do just that.

Just remember this. There is a lot of information below. If you find yourself overwhelmed, just start by using a few tips here and there. This process is simple and direct. Remember, simplicity is brilliance. Don't try to do everything. This guide is simply to give you basic knowledge and options to personalize an athletic protocol to yourself. And again, that only comes down to doing a few things really well.

The Base of Athletic Ability and Performance

- Skill (desired outcome)
- Attributes

The Attributes

- Strength
- Mobility (Strength + flexibility)
- Power (Strength + speed)
- Coordination (Skill acquisition through practice)

The How?

Step 1: Lift heavy weights

- Begin with a good strength training template

Step 2: Lift heavy weights fast

- Train explosively
  - Increase the tempo of ALL your movements to maximum speed and explosiveness on your concentric phase of ALL your exercises
  - Warm up with explosive movements without tiring yourself out
    - Plyometrics
    - Jumps
    - Bounds
    - Sprints
    - Kettlebell/DB Swings
    - Etc.
  - Begin with Olympic lifting variations

Step 3: Get a strong and developed core (don't neglect rotational movements!!)

- Core strength and trunk control
  - Get strong abs
    - Weighted sit-ups
    - Feet Stable Russian twists
    - Kettlebell uppercut

        - Staggered Stance Side Bends
        - Toe-to-bar leg raises
        - Dragon flags
        - Ab Wheels
        - Windshield wipers
        - Decline DB Punch Sit-Up
        - Etc.
    - Note: don't train Abs like a bored housewife doing the ol' "three minute", "burn", or "high-rep" kind of stuff; train them HARD and HEAVY close to FAILURE

Step 4: Get strong in a variety of movements in different planes and directions

- Get strong in weird and awkward movements, positions, and ranges of motion, with fast movement (COORDINATION)
    - Behind the neck presses
    - Snatch grip high pulls
    - DB snatches
    - Cossak Squats
    - ATG Split Squats
    - Jefferson Curls
    - Upright Rows
    - Deficit Push Ups
    - Cleans
    - Etc.

Step 5: Improve coordination and mobility

- This primarily comes down to going deep in your movements and getting stronger through deeper ranges of motion. If you do this correctly, you'll never need a "mobility" day again in your life
    - Train full ROM with the goal of becoming stronger
        - Where you want most muscle and mobility is where you want the most stretch
        - Deep squats
        - Lunges
        - Deep deficit hinges
        - Deep deficit push-ups
        - Deep dips
        - Etc.
    - Train with various (weighted) bodyweight movements and variations
        - Pull-up Variations
        - Row Variations
        - Push-up Variations
        - Dip Variations
        - (Single Leg) Squat Variations
        - *Anything on gymnastics rings (and again, with additional weights if possible)*
    - Incorporate Olympic lifting variations

        - The two main variations:
        - Power/Hang Snatch
        - Power/Hang Cleans
        - As well as their DB variations
        - Other Variations:
        - Push Presses/Jerks
        - High Pulls
        - As well as their DB variations

Ultimate Flexibility Guide

- Strength through length (PNF)
- Supplement with DYNAMIC stretching
- Use static stretching if plateaued to supplement

Step 6: Train plyometrics

- Vertical Jumps
- Horizontal Bounds
- Sprints
- Explosive Push-Up Variations
- Explosive Pull-Up Variations

Bonus — Step 7: Soft acrobatics

- Wrestlers are some of the most athletic people on earth. Part of the warm-up is a series of bodyweight movements, plyometrics, and acrobatics. Wrestlers are practically amateur and mediocre acrobats. Learning these will do wonders for your coordination, proprioception (body awareness in space), and overall control and explosiveness in your body.

- Various rolls
- Handstands
- Macacos
- Aerial and Butterfly Kick Variations
- Front Handsprings
- Back Bridges

- Foot strength (barefoot work)
    - Skipping
    - Barefoot toe walks
    - Hindu squats/sissy squats
    - Calf raises (stretched)
    - Tib raises
    - Sled push

    - Jumping, sprinting, and backwards running

Methods TLDR

- Heavy weights (lift explosively) + bodybuilding + (weighted) calisthenics + jumps and sprints
- Bonus: Olympic lift variations + soft acrobatics
- Incorporate supersets or giantsets for increased cardio and conditioning
- Prime your CNS with Explosive movements, plyometrics, sprints, or a PAP warm-up
    - Can also use various contrast methods
- The Easiest Method: Warm up with 1-3x5-10 plyos with your main movement patterns, not to failure (explosive push-ups, squat jumps, pull-ups to waist, kettlebell swings, dumbbell snatch, etc.)
    - Begin your workouts with a few heavy sets of Olympic lifting variations if you want to take this more seriously
    - Make sure to do reactive plyos
    - Jumps as warm up (tuck jumps, single leg butt kicks, broad jumps, lunge jumps, step up jumps, etc.)
        - Easy variation Broad + tuck jump
        - Power skips
        - Can pick 3-5 plyos for one set for a warm-up
    - 3-10 sets of Sprints 1-2x/week as a warm-up OR on separate days
    - Sled work as warm-up or as burnout
    - Max Explosive burpees as warm-up
    - Replace some isolation exercises with explosive variations and bodyweight movements
        - DB flies to gymnastic ring flies
        - DB bench press to deficit ring push-ups (add weight when possible)
        - Upright rows to snatch grip high pulls
        - Hip thrusts to heavy KB/DB swings
        - Lat pull downs to weighted pull-ups
        - Etc.
- TLDR:
    - Sprint + jump + lift heavy (+ calisthenics)
        - Weights + variety of bodybuilding movements + various bodyweight movements/variations + plyometrics
    - Lift weights fast through a deep range of motion, use bodyweight variations, jumps, heavy carries, swings, and Olympic Weightlifting variations
    - Another way to put it:
        - Olympic lift variations/Plyos/Explosive movements
        - Heavy Lifts
        - Bodyweight Movements with Gymnastic Rings
        - Backfill with bodybuilding
    - Basic acrobatics 1x/week

- **The simplest way to put it:**
  - Continue doing what you are already doing (assuming you are already lifting heavy weights and doing it fast)
  - Throw in some jumps and sprints in your program, either as a warm-up, as a part of a giant set, or on a separate day
  - Incorporate more bodyweight movements
  - Consider basic soft acrobatics + Olympic weightlifting variations
- DO NOT try to do all of these. Just pick a few here and there and experiment with what YOU WANT TO DO

Big Idea of Athleticism

- Who can coordinate their muscles the fastest to apply into an explosive athletic movement?
- Muscle size → muscle strength potential → speed potential → explosiveness

Exercise Index (Athletic)

Note: Again, don't choose everything! Just pick 2-3 movements and master them!

Abs

- Plank
- **Sit up (flat, GHD, Decline, butterfly bench, etc.)**
- **Reverse crunch (+ leg lifts, cross bench, incline candlesticks)**
- **DRAGON Flag (One leg, tuck, eccentric, one leg eccentric, bicycle, straddle)**
- **Kettlebell Uppercut**
- Active Plank
- Weighted Plank
- Mat Crunch
- Cable Crunch
- **Hanging Leg/Knee Raise (Can Be Weighted/Banded)**
- Leg Raise Thrust (Reverse Deadlift)
- Butterfly leg raise/frog kicks
- **Around the World**
- Cable Chop
- Full contact twist
- **Side Bend**
- **Ab Wheel**
- Pallof Press (+ Twist)
- Med Ball Slam
- L Sit
- L Sit Scissor
- Straddle L Sit
- **Hollow Body/Rock**
- **Reverse Squat**
- Dead Bug
- Crunch with Twist
- **Side-to-side leg raise**
- **Windshield wiper**
- Front lever raise
- **Ring rollout**
- Overhead Barbell Situp
- V-Ups
- Twisted V-Ups
- Copenhagen Ring planks
- **Decline Single Arm DB Punch**
- **GHD Halo**

Push-up Variations

- Standard
- Wide
- Close/Diamond
- **Rings**
- **Weighted**
- **Deficit**
- Finger Push up
- Knuckle
- Jackie Chan
- Pike
- Hindu
- **Pseudo Planche**
- Handstand
- Archer/Side to Side
- One Arm
- One Arm Assisted
- **One Arm Feet Elevated**
- **One Arm Assisted Feet Elevated**
- Rocky Push Up
- Mike Tyson push up
- Clap/Explosive
- Spiderman
- RTO Push Up
- One Arm One Leg (Opposite Foot)

Pull-up Variations

- Standard
- **Weighted**
- **Chinups**
- **Sternum**
- **Ring**
- **Wide**
- Close
- Behind the Neck
- Commando
- Assisted One Arm
- One Arm Feet Assisted
- Archer
- Double Rope/Towel
- Thick Bar
- Neutral Grip

- Explosive
- Pulls to Stomach (Pseudo Muscle Up)
- L-Sit (Or Rack Chin)
- Grenade Grip
- Around The World

Dip Variations

- Dips
- **Weighted Dips**
- **Ring Dips**
- **RTO Dips**
- Straight bar Dips
- Feet Assisted Dips
- Jumping Dips
- Bulgarian Dips
- Side to Side Dips
- Russian Dips

Calisthenic Legs

- Bw squat
- **Pistol squat**
- **Bulgarian Split Squat**
- **Reverse lunge**
- **Front elevated split squat**
- **Sissy squat**
- Single sissy squats
- **Nordic curl and Progressions**
- Hip thrust
- Feet elevated deficit single hip thrust
- Platz squat
- **ATG SS**
- **Cossak squat**
- Curtsy Lunge
- Sumo squat
- Bret Contreas lying side abduction
- Copenhagen Abductions
- Hyperextension Adductions
- Jumping Lunge
- Jumping squat
- Jumping BSS
- Jumping Elevated Pistol Squat

Olympic Lifts

- Snatch
- Clean and Jerk
- Power Snatch
- Power Clean
- Hang Snatch
- Hang Clean
- Jerk
- Klokov Press
- Clean Pull
- Snatch Pull
- One Arm Snatch/Clean
- One Arm Swings
- Kneeling High Pull

Plyos/Explosive Movements

- **Sprints**
- **Kettlebell/DB Swing**
- **Single Arm Swings**
- **Weighted Step Ups**
- **Explosive Alternating Step Ups**
- Banded KB swings
- DB Snatch
- DB High Pull
- **Plyo Pushup Variations**
- **Plyo Pullup Variations**
- **Explosive Squat Variations**
- **High Pull Variations**
- **Box Jump**
- Single Leg Box Jump
- Seated Box Jump
- Lateral Box Jumps
- Skater Jumps
- **Depth Jumps**
- **Power Skips**
- Depth Jump to Broad Jump
- **Tuck Jumps**
- **One-legged butt kickers**
- **One-legged tuck jumps**
- **Broad Jumps**

- **Single-Leg Bounds**
- Maasai Style jumps
- **Jump Lunge**
- **DB Jump Lunge**
- Side jumps
- **BSS Jumps**
- **Trap Bar Jump**
- **Ninja Tuck Jumps**
- **Ninja Box Jumps**
- Any Exercises With Bands Or Chains
- Burpee Variations
- Med Ball Slams (With Rotations too, like Sledgehammers)
- Jumping Med Ball Slam
- Med Ball Throws (Side)
- Med Ball Chest Pass
- KettleBell Golf Swings
- **Sled Drags/Pulls/Drives**
- Sled Face Pulls/High Pulls
- Sandbag Cleans
- Sandbag Runs
- Sandbag to Platforms
- Farmer Walks (bodyweight each hand)

Soft Acrobatic Movements

- Handstands
- Handstand walks
- Back Bridge
- Kip-Up
- Front Roll
- Shoulder Roll
- Dive Roll
- Back Roll
- Explosive Back Roll Kip
- Cartwheels
- One Arm Wheels
- Elbow Cartwheel
- Roundoff (+ High Tuck Jump)
- Front Handspring
- Headspring
- Macaco
- Aerials/Butterfly Kick
- Basic flips and tricks as plyometrics

    - Back flip
    - Front flip
    - Side flip
    - Aerials
    - Cheat gainer
    - Tornado/540 kick
    - Cheat 720

Additional Resources

- Anything from Garage Strength
- Pavel Tsatsouline
- The World's Fittest Book by Ross Edgely
- Alec Enkiri
- Brian Alsruhe
- Will Ratelle
- Hard Work Pays Off by Mat Fraser

Uhhh, Can You Dumb It Down, Please???

Let's be honest with each other. You didn't really read the entire guide and soak it in, did you??

No hard feelings. It was a lot of information to take in, despite my attempt to simplify everything to the best of my ability. I'm a nerd, and anything fitness will land easily for me, and is therefore easy for me to produce, like how it is for many of you in terms of music, car stuff, medical stuff, business ideas, collecting heirloom beans, vintage coins, etc.

If there is anything you need to remember, it's that getting your dream physique comes down to three primary things: controlling calories to control your body composition, getting stronger CONSISTENTLY and persistently while staying injury-free, and recovery. Everything that works is just individualized preferences that manage these three things well. Everything that doesn't work, does not account for any of these well at all.

Anyways, here are the main takeaways from each of the guides to make it easy for you to absorb.

Health Guide TLDR

The 4 major buckets of health:

76. Cardio/daily activity guide
    - **Walk 10,000 steps daily**
    - **OR perform the Japanese walking protocol**
        - **30 minutes of alternating intervals of fast walking and slow walking**
        - **30 seconds on, 30 seconds off**
    - **Don't just "do" cardio as an "event" that you resent (unless that is something you enjoy), but find an activity that you enjoy that you don't consider exercise/make it a lifestyle**
        - **Ex:**
        - Dancing
        - Swimming
        - Hiking
        - Skateboarding
        - Martial arts
        - Take the stairs
        - Park farther away
        - Play with kids
        - Buy a dog
        - Play VR
        - Etc.

77. Nutrition
    - ***Key Principle: nutrition and flavor ARE NOT mutually exclusive***
    - **Eliminate all processed foods**
    - **Learn or begin to cook and season all your foods well**
        - **Why?**
        - To make foods that are good and enjoyable ENOUGH that you don't need a "cheat" day

I.e. make every single day a "micro cheat day" with foods that are simultaneously "healthy," satiating, satisfying, and downright enjoyable (at least enjoyable enough)

    - **Buy and cook primarily whole foods (for most people, this will look like lean protein sources, vegetables, fruits, legumes, etc.)**
        - Again, buy and prepare foods you enjoy, not foods you "should" eat
        - High protein and high fiber (fruits and veggies) keep you full the longest with the least amount of calories
        - Therefore you might as well make them enjoyable
        - Make sure to take advantage of good seasonings, condiments, and low calorie sauces
    - **Replace your snacks with zero/low-calorie drinks**
        - **Ex:**
        - Black coffee
        - Tea
        - Water
        - Coconut water
        - Electrolyte drinks
        - Sparkling water
        - Etc.
    - **Have fun and eat foods you enjoy by learning how to cook healthier versions of your favorite foods that are higher in protein and lower in calories**
        - Realistically, most of us eat the same 5-7 meals every day. Therefore, figure out the 5-7 things you like to eat, and make high-protein, low-calorie versions of those
        - YouTube and Google are a great place to start with recipes
        - **Ex:**
        - Cuisines of any kind
        - Protein ice cream
        - Low calorie, high protein burgers
        - Low calorie, high protein pasta
        - Low calorie, high protein sandwiches
        - Anything your mind can think of or crave, simply find the low calorie, high protein version

78. Sleep
    - **Aim for 7-9 hours of sleep daily**
    - **Avoid caffeine after 2 PM**
    - **Avoid excessive alcohol**

- **Get enough physical and mental activity in the day before bed**
- **Sleep and wake up at the same time daily**
- **Process your thoughts and emotions during the day before bed (this is key!)**
- **Make sure your room is dark and cool**
- **Practice deep belly breathing in bed**
- **Try magnesium and ditch the melatonin**
- **Relax your neck, tongue, and face while getting into bed**

79. Resistance training
    - **Lift weights 2-4/week**
        - **Find a program that fits your:**
        - Goals (what you want and value from exercise)
        - Constraints (realistic time commitment, life obligations, stresses, etc.)
        - Preferences (what do you enjoy/not enjoy doing in the gym?)
        - Pick a program from the spreadsheet
    - **Hit each muscle 2-3x/week**
        - About 6-12 sets/week
    - **Lift heavy, intensely, with a full range of motion**
    - **Prioritize big compound movements**
        - Pick 3-5 movements TOPS for each muscle group/movement pattern
        - REMEMBER: less is more
        - Focus on getting stronger on a few exercises with HIGH-QUALITY SETS, rather than doing a lot of exercises with too many sets
    - **Prioritize strength progressions over time in a variety of ways**
    - **Have fun**

Rehab/Mobility TLDR

- How pain works: Pain comes from weakness, leading to a lack of stability, leading to a lack of mobility, which forces your body to overcompensate, which typically leads to pain, due to excessive wear and tear over time, leading to pain...
- SOLUTION: become stronger with the surrounding structures AND THEN the direct structure itself towards Pain-Free Movement Ability

Rehab protocol:

Step 1: Wait for initial inflammation to subside and the injury to heal as much as possible before working on the restoration of strength and ability

Step 2: Don't stop moving, or start moving again, to encourage blood flow

Step 3: Strengthen the affected area indirectly by getting stronger in the structures around the affected area

Step 4: Strengthen the affected area with gentle-to-start exercises for:

- **Easy re-entry into movement in that area**
- **Encourage blood flow for healing**
- **Build and regain basic stability and some mobility**

Step 5: Build new movement ability by getting stronger through a deeper range of motion, from assisted to bodyweight to loaded, ultimately until you can do an exercise through a deep range of motion with progressively heavier weight

Athleticism TLDR

- The myth of functional training:
  - **There is no such thing as "athletic or functional training" where you do a bunch of random kettlebell, band, or whatever movements to make yourself "more athletic."**
  - **All training is "functional"; it only comes down your specific "function" you want**
    - **Athleticism comes down to a few things:**
    - Specific skill (your sport)
    - Explosiveness (which is strength + speed)
    - Therefore, athleticism is about increasing skill in your specific sport and getting stronger and faster
  - If you do not mind some profanity or coarse jokes, check out this playlist for the explanation: https://youtube.com/playlist?list=PL21xpg8kaXhhydER_R4sjTJ9O1LnsHsuD&si=ElJWt_GC5KuJG4r2

- How to actually train for performance
  - **The trait that people look for in "athleticism" is explosiveness; therefore, to be more athletic, you should...**
    - Step 1: Practice your sport (athleticism is skill + explosiveness)
    - Step 2: Sprint
    - Step 3: Jump
    - Step 4: Lift heavy weights fast/explosively (which will also take care of mobility)
    - Perhaps try Olympic lifting + odd lift variations
    - Perhaps try calisthenics/gymnastics rings
    - Treat mobility/core movements like bodybuilding

Parting Words

Here is one thing I want you to notice: the foundation and the connecting thread to everything I've written down is the magic of resistance training towards strength progressions. That is because resistance training is the closest thing to a miracle drug in a pill as you can get. Here is a podcast by Mind Pump for some of the benefits: https://youtu.be/uXsNa5UYXIA?si=sfj5eweUmZwLg1mf. In other words, you want to get stronger through a variety of ways, whether adding weight, reps, getting into deeper joint angles, in odd joint positions, etc.

The defining characteristic of a good exercise program is the intentional focus on making strength progressions.

All methods, modes, and systems of productive training are simply different variations and expressions of this one goal, whether it be for muscle gain, strength gain, performance and athleticism, longevity, health, or other similar objectives.

In fact, training for looks, strength, performance, longevity, rehab, etc., is such an overlapping Venn diagram that it is practically just one giant circle. Therefore, again, the key factor of training should not be simply "confusing the muscle" or whatever random stuff "fitness gurus" will tell you, but about chasing strength progressions over time.

Conversely, just so we are clear, no amount of light kettlebell work, band drills, core drills from some guy on Instagram, doing some strange and trendy stretchy bendy thingies, throwing around 8lb balls, battling rope like you're riding a horse as if you're training to defend the honor of your local village, standing on one leg on a bosu ball like you're training to do battle on an unstable dingy as a pirate, or crawling around on the floor like any animal of your choosing will ever make up for the raw stimulus of simply lifting heavy things in a variety of different ways with the clear and measurable goal of getting stronger. These gimmicky things are entry-level at best, and beyond this, they only serve the purpose of making you appear more well rounded as a coach, while making the trainee tired with needless novelty that will never move the needle towards any given goal, besides only getting slightly better at those specific things.

How do we know this? Because Delan has never had a single original thought in terms of "making up" new methods, modes of training, exercises, etc. (although I have previously thought that I have done so, before figuring out the best minds of the past and the current age have already thought of it).

All I have done is simplify, synthesize, and streamline the best of what we know and have known about the art of exercise for years in a practical manner. The human body hasn't changed in thousands of years. Unless our physiology changes, there is only so much novelty we can introduce to make new and novel gains.

What I am saying is this: there is no need to reinvent the wheel. The architecture of good training is sound. All this guide has done is put together the best information we know about

"good wheels" and made an attempt to put it into one place. In other words, this was not an attempt to reinvent the wheel, but to build the best wheel possible for all occasions.

I suppose all I have left to say about the fitness space is this:

There is nothing new under the sun (or shall we say, the barbell).

The eye is never satisfied with seeing, nor is the ear ever content with hearing (trends; new and novel ideas).

What exists now is what will be, and what has been done is what will be done; there is nothing truly new on earth (in this case, the gym).

Is there anything about which someone can say, "Look at this! It is new"? It was already done long ago, before our time.

Nerd stuff aside, there is nothing new in the gym. Trends come and go in cycles, but foundational principles endure.

Therefore, go out there, train, and become the strongest version of yourself.

Grace and peace.

TRAINING REFERENCE

The Programs + Templates

Housekeeping

How to best use the program

1) Progression from week to week is required to see changes
2) Feel comfortable to customize exercises/ rep ranges if you desire
3) The goal is to accumlate total work load from week to week
4) The means to get generally stronger from week to week
5) Ensure that you are well hydrated, fed, rested; and TRACK workouts
6) READ EVERYTHING FIRST

How to pick a weight to start with

1) Determine the rep range for the given exercise (i.e. 6-12, 5-10, etc.)
2) Pick a weight that isn't too hard to go below the lowest rep or easy to go above the highest rep
3) The weight should be challenging enough to force you to stop before the end of the rep range
4) Push it until you can't do another rep with perfect form (or 0-3 reps shy of failure)
5) Pick a weight that is relatively easy to begin with if you are doing a new movement
6) Do not do the optional exercises until you are ready! Start with the lowest possible workload first!!

How to progress

Double Progression

Start at the low end of the rep range, add 1 rep each week until the you hit the top end of the rep range. Then add weight and repeat

EX: Rep range 8 - 12. Week 1 - 3 sets of 8, Week 2 - 3 sets of 9, Week 3 - 3 sets of 10, etc.

After hitting 3 sets of 12, add 5lbs and repeat weight will be harder to add over time- at around intermediate, expect 5lbs every 3-5 weeks; at advanced, expect every 6-10 weeks

If Double Progression slows to a stop, start adding sets while keeping the weights and reps the same

Dynamic Double Progression

Similar to double progression, but you add weight once you hit the top rep range. Drop the weight for the 2nd set if you can't stay

within the rep range with the same weight. This is most recommended for most or all exercises

EX: Rep range 8-12; Week 1: 100 x 10, 100 x 8, 95 x 10

Week 2: 100 x 12, 100 x 10, 100 x 9

Week 3: 105 x 10, 105 x 8, 100 x 10

Week 4: 105 x 12, 105 x 10, 105 x 8

Week 5: 110 x 9, 110 x 8, 105x 9

Adding sets

Start with 3 sets, then add 1 set per week until hitting 5 sets. Then go back down to 3 sets and add weight. Repeat

For accessory lifts, start with double progression and add sets when needed

Once you plateau, switch the exercise/rep range that is a similar movement pattern and repeat

If you can't add anymore weight, sets, or reps, progress by "controlling the movement," then add one of the other factors

"Shut up, don't care, just tell me what to do"

Start with 3 sets on big compound movements and do double progression (and make sure to pick a challenging weight where you can't do 15 yet); 2 sets on secondary or isolation movements

EX: 3x10-15

Only add weight once you can do 3 sets of 15

Add a set if you are having trouble adding reps and weight

EX: 100lb x 14, 12, 11

Next week, do 4 total sets

For the following week, go back to 3 sets and add weight

Key Principles For Training For Life

Training is really quite simple. All training programs have the same principles that drive gains. Any and all programs and methods work as long as they possess these universal principles. 1. YOU ARE A HUMAN BEING with motivations, values, and desires unique to YOU, therefore you must be truthful with your deepest goals and desires that are UNIQUE and TRUE to YOU- You have certain preferences and biases- There Are certain things and exercises that you will realistically stick to and some that you won't 2. Key Principle: SUSTAINABILITY (Consistency + Genuine Enjoyment = Sustainability)- Ask yourself: could I (probably) do this forever?- If not, ask why and tweak It, keep going for a little while, or adapt it3. Consistency 4. Honest Intensity/ Effort5. Progression over time (are you getting stronger and beating the books over time? -see metrics below)6 Enjoy it; i.e. buy into what you're doing, because love, passion, and deep affection takes you further than "optimal" (And learn to get ABSOLUTELY stoked for teeny tiny progress!)TLDR1. Find the intersection between what you enjoy most and what your goal demands of you (is realistic for you to perform consistently?)2. What is most enjoyable for you?3. But also what is most effective and efficient to reach your goals?4. There will inevitably be some compromise in each bucket, but that is why it is important be honest with your goals to know what compromises are most realistic for you5. There is an inverse relationship between effort and volume; therefore, if you want to get more out of less, train with more effort and less work (i.e., 2-3 of heavy failure training vs, 3-5 sets with a 2-3 reps in reserve) and vice versa

Key Metrics For Progress

Quantity (More on numerical metrics):

1. More Weight

2. More Reps

3. More Sets

Quality (More overall control and mastery of movement):

1. Slower Eccentric (the "lowering" phase) + Concentric Speed

2. Pause at the bottom

3. More range of motion (THIS IS KEY!!!) - Principle: Where you want to grow the most muscle is where you want to create the deepest stretch

Progression Methods

1. Linear Periodization (Strength Specific; Phases in 4 Week Blocks --- Phases in 3 Sets of 10's, 8's, 6's, 5's, 3's, 2's, 1's, 1RM --- Start with 60-65% And Add 2.5% Weekly)

2. Double Progression

3. Dynamic Double Progression

4. Triple Progression (Like Double Progression, But Adds Sets As A Progression Factor)

5. Volumizing Step Loading (Either With Intensity -- Reps -- Or Overall Volume -- Sets) --- EX: In 3 Week Waves; 3x10, 4x10, 5x10, Add 4-6%, 3x8, 4x8, 5x8, Down to 5x1 --- Or 3x10, 3x11, 3x12, etc.

6. Reverse Pyramid Training

7. Top Set + Back-Off Sets/ Amrap

8. Ramping Sets To One Top Set

9. 80/60 Method (3x5 At 80% + 3x17 At 60% --- Master The Weight, But Add 5-10 lbs As Often As Possible --- This is a Secret Weapon To Use For ~ 3-5 Weeks)

10. Tactical Barbell --- 70/80/90% 3-5x 5; 3-5x 3 every 3 weeks; perform the same strength movements 2x/ week --- 75/85/95% in second weekly session at sets of 2 every 3 weeks

11. 12/8/5/3/1 -- 3 sets each; linear progression until all set falls out of range -- Ex: 3x12, add weight until you cannot hit rep target with even 1 set; move onto 8's, then 5's, all the way to 1x1; repeat

12. Two set method--- two high quality all-out sets to failure

Factors:

1. Conjugation: Exercise Rotation and Variation As Novelty

2. Undulation: Varying Volume and Intensity As Novelty

3. Linearity: Adding Weight As Form of Novelty

You don't need all of these methods. Just pick 1-3 that sounds fun and stick with it; method jumping is a straight guaruntee for going nowhere.

My Personal Favorite Methods

1. Dynamic Double Progress2. Reverse Pyramid Training/ Top-Set, Back Off-Set3. Two-Set MethodThe 'Why': these methods are not magical, or the 'best.' However, they allow me to lift heavy, work hard safely (cartharsis), save time, make progress, and have fun.

Q + A

How do I save time in the gym?

1. Perform supersets or giantsets with exercises that don't impact each other. For example, doing biceps and triceps and shoulders back to back together. 2. Use dumbbells/bodyweight movements/machines to avoid warming up for too long. 3. You can also stick to 2 sets per exericise4. Shorten the rest periods5. Perform the main lifts (or your most important lifts) first, and skip everything else

What if I switched mid-program?

You could. The templates were made to be used indefinitely or to be switched if need be. What actually matters is consistent progress in performance. In light of that, if you switched, but still see good consistent strength gains, by all means go for it, especially if life circumstances change. However, hopping from program is NOT conducive to progress and is often harmful to it.

How do I know I'm doing it right?

You should generally be able to feel the muscle, maintain control (look at tempo below), without experiencing pain, too much wobbling, or losing tension in the muscle. If you do, you fix adjust the movement, regress the load, or add the appropriate load so it moves properly. Initially, think "skill," not heavy effort. That comes when the skill is established.

How do I pick the right program for me?

You should start with three things: your HONEST goals, your contraints, and your preferences. Ask yourself: What do you really care about, even if others disagree, what are you realistically willing to do, and what do you like or don't like, assuming you have the experience to know. Once you figure it out, find the one that fits your goals, the realistic number of times you can go to the gym, and plug and play exercises that you enjoy into the template that works for your schedule.

How long should I stay on a program?

They're written to be ran indefinitely. So you can either pick one that you like and run it indefinitely, switch them every 8-12 weeks for experimentation, or switch if and when your life circumstances change.

What if I can't feel the muscle?

Slow down the tempo, reduce the load, adjust the angles, increase the reps or play with the range of motion (usually going deeper is better).Think about the basic, not intricate, function of the target muscle and perform it. Focus on control, not weight in the beginning. Also, feeling a muscle is a skill and takes time. Sometimes you can build a muscle without even feeling it for months.

How do I pick the right exercises?

Your goals should determine your compound movements and the weaknesses in your movements and/or physique should determine your isolation/ accessory exercises to support

your compound movements. Explanation: You should pick exercises that fit your goals and your preferences. As long you it moves you towards your goals, and you enjoy the exercise enough to continue, you should feel free to do it. Again, the goal should always be to get stronger and increase performance. Pick movements that you will enjoy doing that with.Also, along the way you will pick up weaknesses, whether that is visible in your physique or felt in your performance. To address this, simply do the movements that address your weaknesses, or the movements you have been avoiding or not prioritizing.

Why and how should I track progress?

The key to making progress is improving performance overtime. This means that you should always aim to beat the log books every workout, whether or not you actually do so (see "My Progressed Slow. Is That Normal?"). This makes tracking one of the most important things you will do in the gym, so that you are not doing random weights that you feel like doing for the day, or lifting weights that you know perfectly well is within your current ability. You always want to go slightly beyond. Here is what to track in order to beat it week to week/ month to month:Exercise WeightSets + repsRPE (proximity to muscular failure on a scale of 1-10)

What if I don't have the right equipment?

Substitute a different variation in the same movement pattern or muscle group.

When should I switch exercises?

Once you plateau, get bored, or switch goals. A true plateau sits for 2-3+ months, especially if you are more advanced.

What should I do if I miss a workout?

Either pick up where you left off or continue to the next workout.

What if I feel pain during the movement?

Same principles above. (What if I don't feel the muscle?)Also, you can either swap the movement for the same movement pattern, same muscle group, drop the weight, or regress the movement. Muscular discomfort is good, but joint pain in not.

When should I switch programs?

These templates are made to be used indefinitely, since they are designed with personal preference and intuition in mind. Switch programs if or when your goals, life circumstances, or personal preferences change.

Should I always follow the order exactly?

The exercises are ordered by either heaviest to less heavy, or by importance to avoid overlap. However, you can do the heavy compound movements first and rearrange the accessory or isolation exercise if need be.

What should the tempo be?

It depends on the goal. I typically recommend an explosive concentric, controlled eccentric (about 1-2 seconds).Besides the intellegent use of some body english for heavy weights, there should be no jerking, bouncing, or collapsing.

How long does it take to make progress?

Strength takes weeks. Muscle takes about 6-12 weeks to begin to start seeing noticable progress. 6 months you can look significantly different. 1-3 years you can look like a new person5-10 years for absolutely extraordinary results towards your genetic limit This is all assuming you are consistent and intentional

How long should each session be?

45-75 minutes long. Your rest times, exercise selection, intensity, volume, busyness of the gym, and your tendency to talk to other people at the gym all affect your time in the gym.

When should I deload?

Most people will deload every 4-12 weeks, depending on experience. You should deload on a week where your performance tanks, feel fatigued, and unfresh. Personally, that is every 6-8 weeks for me. You can either do a proper deload, or skip the gym altogether and come back after a week of rest.

My progressed slowed. Is that normal?

Yes. As you get more advanced, your progress will slow. Here is the approximate normal rate of progression on heavy compound movements:Beginner: add 5-10lbs/ 1+reps every 1-2 weeks (~120lbs+/year)Intermediate: add 5-10lbs/ 1 rep every 4-5 weeks (~60lbs+/year)Advanced: add 5-10lbs/ 1 rep every 6-8 weeks (~30lbs+/year)EX: if bench press starts with 95lbs. After 1 year it increases to 215lbs. After 2-3years, 275lbs. After 3-5 years, 305lbs+Note: this is a super generic example, assuming he is consistent

How long should I rest?

1-5 minutes, depending on the lift or goal of the lift. Heavy loads: 3-5 minutesModerate loads: 2-3 minutesLighter loads: 1-2 minutesIn reality, it doesn't really matter, outside of the heavy loads. Do what feels best and allows you to lift heavy.

Is there a feeling I should aim for?

Soreness, tirednes, sweatiness, the pump, burning, etc. are all proxies of training hard, but are not the indicators of genuine progress. What matters is consistent progress in strength and performance overtime. See "Why and how should I track progress."

I've plateaued. What should I do?

First, take audit of your sleep, nutrition, focus, and life stress. A true plateau lasts 2-3+ months if these elements are dialed in.Consider a deload. Continue after the deload. If these don't work, switch exercises, attack your weak points, apply more effort, adjust your volume, lower your weight and restart your progression, or switch goals and comeback when to the current goal when you're fresh

Can I add exercises or cardio?

Sure. There are the "optional accessory" slots for adding things you want to add.However, there is an inverse relationship between effort, volume, and frequency. Try to increase your effort first in all of your exercises first, before you add any new exercises. As for cardio, you can do it as a warm up, afterwards for vibes, or on off days to stay moving.

What if I lose motivation or get bored?

Honesty and confession = meaningSteady progress through genuine effort = motivationLaziness, insecurity, boredom, or lack of motivation stems from lack of meaning and progress. You must be honest with your motives on what you really want from the gym to maintain motivation and commit to honestly expressing yourself, which can be a very difficult thing to do.Truth is, being bored comes from not making progress, making slow progress, making progress towards goals you don't care about, or having no goals to strive towards. That said, you should focus on being consistent with your routine, not on how you feel. If you consistently see you numbers and performance increase, along with your physique, you will have new waves of motivation. Just stay consistent.

How do I warm up?

Get warm. It doesn't matter how you do it. You can get in the sauna, do some light cardio, or light band exercises to warm up your joints and muscles.The simplest way, is to do lighter sets of the first exercise you are planning to start with, perform 2-5 warm up sets, and ascend until your first proper working set.

How do I bias towards certain muscles?

Gear your compound movements towards your target muscle by either stretching them or going wider. Obviously, get stronger. Ex: to work on quads on squat, take a closer stance to stretch your quads more. To target your glutes, go wider to stretch them.Also pick and perform isolation exercises and add an extra in the "optional accessory" slot for your target muscle. Also perform them before other exercises.

Consistency vs. intensity?

You need both. To find consistency, you need to be honest with why you want to workout. For example, not enough people are honest about the fact that they want to simply look good. They only admit to part of their motive with half honesty, like being strong or healthy or whateverYou also need to figure out a plan that you enjoy enough and that is realistic for you to stick to long enough to make progress in your performance. If you are honest, realistic, and have fun in the process, it is much easier to apply effort towards the things that are meaningful to you.

Do I need to stretch?

Short answer: no. Long answer: not really.If you lift weights and focus on performing full range of motion and deep stretches, then it is unnecessary.However, if you simply like the sensation of stretching, find it relaxing, or want to build more mobility without weights, go for it.

Should I workout if I am still sore?

Yes.

Can the same template work for men and women?

Yes. The only difference between training for men and women are goals in GENERAL. Men tend to want bigger arms, chest, abs, and such.Women tend to want bigger glutes, legs, tighter waist, and toned arms. You can use the same template, just personalize it with different exercise selection and volume to bias towards your personal goals. Both will still want to get strong in striving towards their goals.

Is there an objectively best way to train?

No. Training is more of an art than a science. Again, it all depends on your goals, contraints, and personal prefences. However the best ingredient to training is consistent hard effort towards strength gains.

How much does optimization matter?

Not much. Just start, enjoy yourself getting stronger across time, and have fun. Do these and you are well on your way. Anything else is simply a distraction.

Templates vs. consistency and effort

Odin sacastically asked Thor, "are you Thor, god of hammers?" The source of your progress will be your consistency and effort towards improving strength and performance across time. Any template will only focus these into something productive.The templates are simply intelligently designed arrangements of exericises to avoid burnout, unnecessary fatigue, stagnation, and setbacks. They replace guesswork with open individualized structure. So the templates are not magic. But they are intelligently designed.

How many sets? 2, 3, or 4? TELL ME!

As a beginner, you'll need less overall work to grow. As you grow into intermediate, you'll need more overall. As you go into the advanced territory, you'll need less again, since the heavier and harder you go, the more effective the set is.TLDR; the harder you go, the less you need. The easier you go, the more you need to make up for the lack of effort. True effort (earned pain tolerance as you gain experience) comes as a skill as you advance. The better you get at it, the less volume you need.

Low, medium, or high reps? TELL ME!

They can all build muscle equally. Muscle gain leads to strength.Strength gains leads to muscle. Higher reps serve as a base builder (work capacity, rehab, muscle, mobility, etc.), while lower reps build the ceiling of max capacity (absolute strength and muscle). Medium gets the best of both worlds. Do them all.

I feel gym-timidated. How do I deal with this?

This is very normal. Almost everyone has felt that and only learns to feel 'at home' later on. Here are a few things that might help you:1. Most people are too focused on themselves to focus on you. 2. Other people feel the same way3. The most jacked person is likely your biggest cheerleader on the inside, and are often the kindest, because they remember what it was like to be new as wellTo feel confident, walk in with a plan, execute it to the best of your ability with high effort, track it, then do it again until you feel comfortable

What is good technique?

Good technique depends on the goal. Here are two general ways I define "good technique for two broad goals:General strength and muscle: to be able to lift as heavy as possible, with full range of motion, while hitting the target muscle as effectively as possible, while being as safe as possibleRehab/Mobility: as much control as possible to drive blood flow, restore and as much range and movement ability as possible, in order to get as strong as possible within these parameters

What's the best way to improve technique?

Three things:1. Pausing 2. Tempo work 3. Focus on the feeling in the musclePrinciple: begin with a weight that is both 1) CHALLENGING AND 2) you can control the weight

Understanding Intensity and Effort

The Role of Intensity and Effort

Intensity: Objective measure of reps in reserve (RIR); proximity of 1 rep max (1RM)RIR vs. RPE: "reps in reserve"/ "rate of perceived exertion"; they are similar, but are the inverse of one anotherEffort: Subjective measure of difficulty. How hard does it feel like you are going on a scale of 1-10? Volume: total amount of work per muscle (typically used with number of sets, i.e. 3 sets of x)Frequency: how often you work a muscle per weekThe inverse relationship between effort, volume, and frequency: the more effort you exert, the less overall work you'll need; the more volume you use, the less effort you need. Hierarcy of importance: effort, frequency, volume Practical application:RIR For strength specific (if strength is defined as 1RM): 1-3 RIR; no maxing, grinding, or failure on heavy setsRIR for hypertrophy: go to 0-1 RIR or failure on all movementsVolume: 2-3 hard sets (assuming you are pushing yourself, otherwise, 4-5 sets can be used to make up for you lack of effort, which I clearly would not recommned)Frequency: 1-3 times per muscle group/ movement patternYou should always treat every movement like they are a main movement and never go easy on any exercise EVER, therefore place your most important movements earlier in your workoutEffort in training should always be high

RIR SCALE

RIR | Definition

0.0 | Concentric Failure, you physically cannot do another rep before resting

0.5 | Could have done slightly more weight, but not another rep

1.0 | One rep shy of failure

1.5 | One rep shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight

2.0 | Two reps shy of failure

2.5 | Two reps shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight

3.0 | Three reps shy of failure

3.5 | Three reps shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight

4.0 | Four reps shy of failure

RPE SCALE

RPE | Definition

10.0 | Concentric Failure, you physically cannot do another rep before resting

9.5 | Could have done slightly more weight, but not another rep

9.0 | One rep shy of failure

8.5 | One rep shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight

8.0 | Two reps shy of failure

7.5 | Two reps shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight

7.0 | Three reps shy of failure

6.5 | Three reps shy of failure and could have done slightly more weight
6.0 | Four reps shy of failure

The Effective Reps Model

In building muscle and gaining strength, tension in the muscle matters most. Therefore, in a set taken close to failure, only the hard reps that slow down involuntarily, are the only reps that matter for strength and muscle.This is why getting stronger (more weight, reps, control, etc.) with hard sets (and reps) is the only thing that matters, because they contribute to Progressive TENSION overload

Signs of True Effort

1. Change of facial expression or color2. Slowing of the movement/ Difficulty at the sticking point 3. Inability to speak4. As well as shaking and/or squirming 5. Involuntary guttural noises (not voluntary shouting)6. “Cluster singles” towards the end of the set7 Resetting for every rep towards the end, 8. The need for a few deep breaths9. Losing 3+ reps in the subsequent sets10. Inability to perform another rep (muscular failure) 11. Low-grade anxiety before the next set (stalling and the need to convince yourself to do the next set)12. Muslce irradiation- Every exercise/ rep feels like a full-body exercise (Ex: you tighten your entire body to squeeze out another curl— this example shows that even an isolation exercise should feel this hard!)Key Principle: Have a goal (5 more lbs, 1 more rep, etc.) every time you walk into the gymReal hard training makes you think only one rep ahead, without back-to-back reps (the inability to think about doing more than 1 rep, but doing it anyway) This forces you to teach yourself to slow down, still your mind, and brace your body to push yourself with FOCUSOne sure fire way to know you're not training with ample effort: you end your sets suddenly without a slow grindy rep and/or slowing yourself down enough to catch a few breaths to grind out 1 or 2 more reps (the speed of the last few reps tell all!)

Tips For Applying True Effort

1. The safety of failure precedes training to failure - make sure you learn and practice how to bail a lift2. Have mini goals before each every set (your sets should make you nervous)3. Summon your demons and become an exorcist4. Think only one rep ahead5. Detach from PR's, while always aiming for them6. Get tight and stiff in your body to stabilize for squeezing out extra reps7. Actually push until you can't (practice this as a SKILL)8. Lower your volume9. Learn to calm your mind before each set and during every rep (this assumes you are training hard and heavy enough to be nervous before each set - and you should!) 10. High standards, high grace- without high standards, you will not become extraordinary. Without grace or compassion when you fail (which you will, guarunteed) you will lose heart. You need the combination of aiming high, while being kind to yourself along the way. 11. If you feel like you can do "extra work," you didn't work hard enough in the first place. Don't be "extra" in the amount of work you do, but be "extra" in your quality of work 12. As you beginner, lifting heavy with effort matters most. Technique matters more as you get stronger

A Note on Tracking Workouts

Key Metrics to keep track of

Key metrics to keep track of:1. Exercise2. Weight3. Sets and reps4. RPEReason: to aim to beat your previous numbers and hit a new PR every weekCaveat: This won't happen once you are more advanced, though the intention should be the same nontheless. (See "How Long Does It Take To Make Progress" in the Q+A section)

How do I track my workouts properly?

1. Find the template that works best for you2. Plug and play the exercises that you like (this is also an ongoing process)3. Plug in the number of sets you use4. Plug in the number of reps you use each set with commas (EX: 10, 8, 9)5. Duplicate the tab from week to week and update with new numbersNote: Use the "sample program/ Delan's program" as inspiration

Example:

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern	Back squat	3.0	12,10,9	225.0	
Horizontal push	Incline press	3.0	11,10,9	95.0	
Horizontal pull	Chest supp. row	2.0	10,10,8	50.0	
Hinge	RDL	2.0	10,9,8	185.0	
Optional acc.	Upright row	2.0	15,15,13	100.0	
Optional acc.	Hyperextensions	2.0	15,12,10	80.0	
Biceps	DB curls	2.0	11,9,9	30.0	
Abs	Decline sit ups	2.0	15, 13, 10	100.0	

Next Week:

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern	Back squat	3.0	12,12,9	225.0	
Horizontal push	Incline press	3.0	12,11,10	95.0	
Horizontal pull	Chest supp. row	2.0	10,10,9	50.0	

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge	RDL	2.0	11,9,8	185.0	
Optional acc.	Upright row	2.0	13,12,12	110.0	
Optional acc.	Hyperextensions	2.0	15, 13, 12	90.0	
Biceps	DB curls	2.0	9,8,8	35.0	
Abs	Decline sit ups	2.0	11,10,8	110.0	

Strength Standards

Why are strength standards important?

Perfomance in the gym = physique in the streets (or wherever you happen to be). They also simply give you realistic goals to aim for as you advance. There are no such thing as jacked naturals that are not strong. That is because there is a very strong correlation between strength and your physique. If you believe there is more that you want out of your physique, set some new strength standards and work hard for it. The worst thing in the gym is to be aimless with your time. Having goals will give you purpose and fire in the gym. Hit these numbers and you will be jacked and strong. There is no way you won't be. Note: These are for general strength and muscle. I am not thinking about these standards with powerlifting in mind. I am thinking about this with full range of motion, with no jerking, no momentum, with decent control of the weight. These are also GENERAL standards. Everyone's body is different (genetics, limb lengths, weight, age, etc.), therefore you will not always hit these perfectly as you advance. However, if you get relatively close to these and you are satisfied with your physique, that will likely be good enough. If you are starting out, simply aim for the 1st tiered standards. Aim for the next one until you feel satisfied with your performance or physique.If you train seriously (consistent, hard effort, avoid injuries, address weaknesses) you can get to "Good" - "Great" range within 3-5 yearsDecent: should be very achievable within 6-12 months, 18 at the most. This is a very good base to strive towards for further strength goalsGood: achievable within 1-3 years of consistent training. Can take 5-10 years if inconsistent. At this level, you are stronger than most at your local gym.Great: achievable within 5-10 years. If you are here, you are likely one of the strongest people anywhere you go!Also, I have left most of them to be the same, but some of the rep ranges are different for men and women. That is because men and women have generally different goals. How to determine strength standards:Take your bodyweight (or goal bodyweight) and multiply it by the standards below for each lift. That is your goalDO NOT BE OVERWHELMED. SIMPLY INTERNALIZE THAT YOU SHOULD ALWAYS AIM TO MAKE PROGRESS. PRIORITIZE 3 GOALS AT A TIME. TRY HARD. HAVE A GOAL. AND HAVE FUN!

Male Standards

Upper Body Lifts

Bench Press: Decent: BW x 1.1-1.2 for 4-6 reps/ 225 for 4-6Good: BW x 1.5-1.6 for 4-6 reps/ 275 for 4-6Great: BW x 1.7+ for 4-6 reps/ 315 for 4-6Incline Bench Press:Decent: BW x 1-1.2 for 4-6 reps/ 185 for 4-6Good: BW x 1.3-1.4 for 4-6 reps/ 225 for 4-6Great: BW x 1.5-1.6 for 4-6 reps/ 275 for 4-6Overhead/ Seated DB Press:Decent: BW x .6-.7 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .8-.9 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1-1.1 for 4-6 reps(Weighted) Dips:Decent: BW x .4-.5 for 4-6 reps / 10-15Good: BW x .7-.8 for 4-6 reps / 20-30Great: BW x 1.1-1.2 for 4-6 reps / 40+Weighted Pull-Up:Decent: BW x .3-.4 for 4-6 reps Good: BW x .5-.6 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x .7-.8 for 4-6 repsOR Bodyweight (if you're already quite heavy i.e. 200+ lbs)Decent: 8-12Good: 12-15Great: 15-20+Bent Over Row:Decent: BW x .9-1 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x 1.2-1.4 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1.6+ for 4-6 repsDumbell Curls:Decent: BW x .2 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .3 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x .35-.4+ for 4-6 repsSkullcrushers:Decent: BW x .4-.5 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .6 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x .7-.8 for 4-6 repsLateral Raises:Decent: 20-25 lbs for 8-15 repsGood: 30-35 lbs for 8-15 repsGreat: 40+ lbs for 8-15Upright Rows:Decent: 50-60 lbs for 8-15 repsGood: 80-100

lbs for 8-15 repsGreat: 100-135+ lbs for 8-15 repsIncline Dumbbell Face Pull:Decent: 20-25 lbs for 8-15 repsGood: 30-35 lbs for 8-15 repsGreat: 40+ lbs for 8-15 reps

Lower Body Lifts

Squat:Decent: BW x 1.3 for 4-6 reps/ 315 for 4-6Good: BW x 1.8 for 4-6 reps/ 365 for 4-6Great: BW x 2.1-2.3 for 4-6 reps/ 405 for 4-6Bulgarian Split Squat:Decent: BW x .8 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x 1-1.2 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1.4-1.5 for 4-6 repsAny Lunge Variation:Decent: BW x .6 for 4-6 reps Good: BW x .8 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1.2+ for 4-6 repsDeadlift:Decent: BW x 1.6 for 4-6 reps/ 365 for 4-6Good: BW x 2-2.2 for 4-6 reps/ 405 for 4-6Great: BW x 2.4-2.6+ for 4-6 reps/ 455 for 4-6Romanian Deadlift:Decent: BW x 1.2 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x 1.6 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 2 for 4-6 reps

Abs

Weighted Sit-Ups:Decent: BW x .1-.2 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .3-.4 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x .6+ for 8-15 repsHanging Leg Raises:Decent: knees to chest for 8-15 repsGood: to parallel for 8-15 repsGreat: toes to bar for 8-15 reps Weighted Hanging Leg Raises:Decent: BW x .05 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .15 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x .25 for 8-15 repsLying or Bench Leg Raises: (If you cannot perform hanging leg raises yet)Decent: from barely off the ground to slightly above hips for 8-15 repsGood: from barely off the ground to vertical legs for 8-15 repsGreat: from barely off the ground to vertical legs with weightAb Wheel:Decent: Fully stretched out on knees for 8-15 repsGood: Fully stretched out, full hip exension on knees for 8-15 repsGreat: Standing for 8-15 repsL-Sit:Minimum: one leg assisted for 15-30 seconds both sidesDecent: 30 secondsGood: 45 secondsGreat: 60+ secondsDragon Flags:Decent: 4-6 reps, OR 8-10 reps with bent hipsGood: 8-10 repsGreat: 12-15 reps

Female Standards

Upper Body Lifts

Bench Press: Decent: BW x .7 for 4-6 reps/ 65 for 4-6Good: BW x 1 for 4-6 reps/ 95 for 4-6Great: BW x 1.25-1.4 for 4-6 reps/ 135 for 4-6Incline Bench Press:Decent: BW x .6 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .8 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1-1.1 for 4-6 repsOverhead/ Seated DB Press:Decent: BW x .25 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .6 for 4-6 reps Great: BW x .7 for 4-6 reps(Weighted) Dips:Decent: BW x .2 for 4-6 reps / BW x 5-8Good: BW x .4 for 4-6 reps / BW x 10-15Great: BW x .5 for 4-6 reps / BW x 20-25(Weighted) Pull-Up:Decent: BW x .2 for 4-6 reps / BW x 3-6Good: BW x .4 for 4-6 reps / BW x 8-12Great: BW x .5+ for 4-6 reps / BW x 15-20Bent Over Row:Decent: BW x .6 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .8 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x 1-1.1 for 8-15 repsDumbell Curls:Decent: BW x .12 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .2 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x .28+ for 8-15 repsSkullcrushers:Decent: BW x .25 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .4 for 8-15 reps Great: BW x .5 for 8-15 reps

Lower Body Lifts

Squat:Decent: BW x 1.1 for 4-6 reps/ 135 for 4-6Good: BW x 1.6 for 4-6 reps/ 185 for 4-6Great: BW x 2 for 4-6 reps/ 225 for 4-6Bulgarian Split Squat:Decent: BW x .7 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x 1 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1.2+ for 4-6 repsAny Lunge Variation:Decent: BW x .5 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x .7-.8 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1 for 4-6 repsDeadlift:Decent: BW x 1.4 for 4-6 reps/ 185 for 4-6Good: BW x 1.8 for 4-6 reps/ 225 for 4-6Great: BW x 2.2+ for 4-6 reps/ 275 for 4-6Romanian Deadlift:Decent: BW x 1 for 4-6 reps Good: BW x 1.5 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 1.7+

for 4-6 repsHip Thrust: Decent: BW x 1.75 for 4-6 repsGood: BW x 2.2 for 4-6 repsGreat: BW x 2.7-3+ for 4-6 reps

Abs

Weighted Sit-Ups:Decent: BW x .1 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .25 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x .5 for 8-15 repsHanging Leg Raises:Decent: Knees to chest for 8-15 repsGood: to parallel for 8-15Great: toes to bar for 8-15Weighted Hanging Leg Raises:Decent: BW x .05 for 8-15 repsGood: BW x .1 for 8-15 repsGreat: BW x .2 for 8-15 repsLying or Bench Leg Raises: (If you cannot perform hanging leg raises yet)Decent: from barely off the ground to slightly above hips for 8-15 repsGood: from barely off the ground to vertical legs for 8-15 repsGreat: from barely off the ground to vertical legs with weightAb Wheel:Decent: knees, full reach for 8-15 repsGood: on knees, full reach, full hip extension for 8-15 repsGreat: standing for 8-15 repsL-Sit:Decent: 20-30 secondsGood: 30-45 secondsGreat: 60+ secondsDragon Flags:Decent: 3-5 reps OR 8-10 with bent hipsGood: 6-8 repsGreat: 8-12 reps

Plateau Checklist

So you've plateaued? Here's why

1. You're inconsistentThis should come as no surprise at all. Ask yourself honestly: have you ever been to the gym consistenty for one whole year? Even 6 months straight? If you go to the gym for 6 weeks consistently, take a week off, come back, and take another three days off, come back, and take more time off, then you will never go where you want to go. That is why it is crucial for you to be honest with what you want out of the gym and be realistic with many days you can truly commit. You can make all kinds of gains with as little as 2-3 days a week if you train intelligently. You just have to be realistic with what you can do and stick to it honestly. 2. You care too much about volumeYou watched too many influencers online or seen so many workout programs that tell you to do a whole bunch of exercises, sets, or both (i.e. volume), so you think you have to do a bunch of work to grow volume. What this might look like, for example, is doing:Bent over rowsPullupsT-bar rowsLat pulldownsPulloversFace pullsRear delt fliesAll for 4-5 sets of 8-12 or whatever.....Why? This is simply unproductive. Doing too much volume is like edging. The only reps that grow you are the hard reps at the end because tension builds muscle. The reason people will do a lot of volume is to make up for the lack of intensity. Why do a whole bunch of easy reps to get tired when you can simply aim for the hard and intense reps in the first set? If you work intensely with one, maybe 2 exercises, that can easily and more efficiently replace 5 exercise3. You do not focus on intensity with the INTENTION to make progress This is something I alluded to above. Your goal in the gym should always be to make a new PR (personal record) every single time. Of course, it is not realistic to do so with every single exercise, but it is the mindset and intent that counts. You can always come in and get 5 more pounds, 1 more rep, a little more more control, a little bit more stretch, on at least one exercise. Never leave the gym without a single "plus 1" with at least one exercise. Ever. 4. You only care about your compound liftsYou push your efforts on your squats, bench, deadlifts, overhead presses, rows, and pullups. However, you treat your isolation work like an afterthought and you don't push for PR's on them. This is an issue, because it is often the isolation work that will help you push past long plateaus. It is usually the lack of effort on isolation lifts that keep your weaknesses weak. 5. You lift too heavy all the timeYou've discovered the value of pushing yourself, and now you think maxing out the weights will continue giving you progess. The issue with this is recovery. If you are always pushing too much, you might not be recovering fast enough to keep up with your ambitions, so you'll come in beat up, sore, aching, tired and losing motivation. This does not give you an excuse to go easy, but learning restraint once you become addicted to heavy weights and hard work when you need it will help you make progress much faster than always trying to do more. You need to have cycles of pushing, as well as cycles of mastering the weight and the movement6. You have bad techniqueYou are simply moving the weight and don't feel it where you should. You don't go all the way down, you swing the weight too much, you're not intentional, and you don't feel the muscle. Slow down, chill out, standardize the movement with full range of motion and intensity. 7. You're bored with your training You're doing stuff you don't care about because you think it's required for progress. There are many ways to skin a cat and training is more of an art than it is a science. As long as you are getting stronger in the muscle/movements that you care about, it can be any kind of exercise, variation, method, etc. as long as it stays within the required guardrails to faciliate progress. Don't force yourself to do things you hate. Pick something that you like, or at least don't despite, and you will see far greater progress and motivation.8. You've fallen into the specialization trap You think you have to train like a pro powerlifter or bodybuilder to grow, so you use ultra specialized and specific programs and techniques that are not designed for general strength and size. Unless you want to be a powerlifter or a bodybuilder, these types of programs

or techniques will not help you and will not get you to your goal. In fact, they will probably be too time consuming, boring, and lead to lack luster results if you follow them. 9. You don't switch exercises If you have used an exercise for a really long time, chances are that you have adapted to it. Of course, you can keep the exercise in and change how you do it, but if you are getting bored with an exercise, you can always switch it to a different variation and come back later when you are fresh. Changing the exercise changes the stimulus, which will give you fresh gains. 10. You don't reset your techniqe or weight You are doing the exact same exercise with the same weight, the same cadence, same volume, and you are plateaued. If you want to keep the exercise simply because you enjoy it, you should reset the weight or the technique to create more space to make more progress, or to create a fresh stimulus11. You don't play around with different rep rangesYou always do the same reps, so you've adapted to them12. You are unrealistic with your expectationsYou expected to become Superman yesterday. Changing your body takes time. Becoming strong, seeing patterns, addressing weaknesses, and making switches takes a lot of time and energy to adjust. Give yourself grace. Take your time. You'll make new gains in no time. 13. You don't track your workouts You come in and wing it. You try to remember it in your head. You don't have the neccessary information to intentionally add slighly more weight, get your "plus one's", or to master the already heavy weight you used last week. Because of that, you don't actually know if you are making progress. 14. You don't address your weaknesses.You only do things you like and never do things you suck at. Therefore, your strength is hindered by your weakest links, and you notice weaknesses and imbalances in your body. 15. Diet You need to eat just enough to recover and grow from your workouts. (not too much, food doesn't "cause" growth. It "permits" growth)

Solutions

1. Find a realistic amount of days that works for you to be consistent 7Be realistic with your life, your obligations, your energy, etc. From there, pick the amount of days you can train and stick to it. It is better to be consistent with less, than to be inconsistent with more. 2. Focus on good techniqueGood technique is the ability to lift as heavy as possible, while hitting the muscle as effectively and efficiently as possible, as safe as possible. Standardize your technique, make sure it is the same every time, and focus on FULL RANGE OF MOTION3. Drop the volume and focus on intensity THROUGH good techniqueIf there's anything you need to know, it's this: the only sets that matter are the hard ones that feel heavy. The only reps that matter are also the hard ones that feel heavy. Once you have your technique down, focus on gettting your PR's. Never leave the gym without a PR. Always go for 5 more pounds, 1 more rep, or a little more mastery over the weight (same weight/reps, but feels lighter; more control, more range of motion, etc.)Always aim to be 0-2 RIR with heavy compounds and 0 RIR with isolations4. Treat every exercise with intensity like a main movementDon't just treat your compound movements with intensity. Treat your isolation movements like you are going to compete with them. Treat them with the same intensity, and even more. Often when we plateau, your isolations will help end the plateaus if you continue hitting new PR's5. Do things that you actually likePick exercises you know you will enjoy making progress on and you will keep progressing. 6. Address your weaknesses Figure out where you are weak, either in your lifts or in the mirror. Begin working on those weaker muscle groups to bring them up so that they will no longer be the weak link .7. Switch exercises, reset your weights, change your rep range, or reset techniqueAnother valid way to break a plateau is to switch the exercise to change the stimulus. Push that new movement until you hit a plateau and switch back to make new PR's. If you want to keep the current exercise, you can simply lower the weight and push it up again, or focus on other rep ranges that you have not used, or change the technique or variation 8. You must develop the SKill of pushing through and trusting the processMany people get stuck either analyzing what to do or spend too much time doing mindless work. You want to be able to work hard and smart. Once you have

decided on a plan, you must be able to stick to it long enough to see some results before making any kinds of switches.

Exercises and Rep Ranges

Squat Patterns | Hinge Patterns | Horizontal Push | Horizontal Pull (Back) | Vertical Push | Vertical Pull | Variations (applies to any exercise)

Back Squat | Deadlift | Flat Barbell Bench (BB) Press | Bent Over Rows | BB Overhead Press (OHP) | Lat Pulldowns | Pauses (top, middle, or bottom)

Front Squat (or Goblet Squat) | Romanian Deadlift (RDL) | Dumbbell (DB) Bench Press | Dumbbell Rows | Seated DB OHP | Pull Ups | Deeper stretches

Sumo Squat (Wide Stance) | Stiff Legged Deadlift (SLDL) | Low Incline Bench Press | Cable Rows | Behind the Neck Press | Feet Assisted Pull Ups | Slower eccentric

Parallel Box Squat | Good Morning | Push ups or Dips (+Variations) | Chest Supported Rows | Arnold Press | Machine Assisted Pull Ups | Wider grip or stance

Quad Accessories (+ Single Leg; also great for glutes) | Hinge Accessories (Glutes/Hamstrings) | Chest Accessories | Back Accessories | Shoulder Accessories | Lat Accessories | Closer grip or stance

Heel Elevated Squat Or Sissy Squats (banded) | Hip Thrusts | Dumbbell Flies | Face Pulls | Lateral Raises (+ Incline/ Chest Supp.) | Cable Pullovers | Different or weaker angle

Walking Lunges OR Reverse Lunges | Hyperextensions | Cable Flies | Y/T Raises | Face Pull | Dumbbell Pullovers | Disadvantaged or weak variations

Bulgarian Split Squats OR Ass to Grass Split Squats | Leg Curls | Incline DB Flies | Monkey Shrugs | Upright Rows | Lat Pull In | Heavier weight with "body english"

Above Knee Step Up (Glutes) OR Pistol Squat (Quads) | Nordic Curls (+ progressions) | Gymnastics Rings Flies | Kelso Shrugs | Lu Raise | Humble Row | Lighter weight with strict technique

Biceps | Triceps | Abs | Calves | Glute Med (Hips/ "Top shelf") | Obliques | Forearms

EZ Bar Curls | Cable Pushdowns | Leg Raises/ Reverse Crunch | Donkey Calf Raises | Machine abduction | Side bends | Reverse Curls

DB Curls | French Press | Weighted Sit Ups/ Decline Sit Ups | Standing Calf Raise | Lying Side Abduction Hip Thrust | Windshield wipers | Hammer Curls

Incline Curls | DB Skullcrushers | Dragon Flags | Single Leg Calf Raises | Standing Hip Abduction | Pallof press + twist | Pronation Curls/ Hammer-Reverse Curls

Hammer Curls | JM Press | Ab Wheels | Seated Calf Raises | Cable Glute Kickbacks | Russian/ Landmine twists | Wrist Curls/ Extensions

Preacher Curls | Double Rope Pushdown | Cable Crunch | Bent Leg Calf Raise | Frog Hip Thrust | Side-Side leg raises | Anything with Fat Gripz

Cossak Squat

Rep Ranges

Movement Type | General Strength & Muscle | Basic Strength | Absolute Strength (Heaviest) | Heavier loads is more strength specific and helps you lift

more weight for more reps over time | Number of sets | Mindset | RIR (Reps in reserve) | Best uses

Compounds | 6-12 | 3-6 | 1-3 | Lighter loads and higher volumes builds the skill, coordination, endurance and general strength to prepare you for strength | 2 | You better make this count and go all out, leaving nothing on the table (all out mentality) | 0 | Best to get the most out of least amount of volume by increasing weight

Accessory & var. | 6-15 | 5-10 | 1-5 | Intelligently putting it all together over time gives the most general strength and muscle as possible (EX: starting with "gen strength & muscle", progressing all the way over to "absolute strength", rinse and repeat)Can also train in 3 week waves | 3 | You can still go very hard, but can scale back the effort a tad bit to get more work in (moderate-hard) | 0-1 | Best of both worlds; less psychologically demanding and less stressful on recovery

Isolations | 8-30/ OR 8-15 (practically) | 8-15 | 5-12 | TLDR; higher reps builds the base, heavy weights raises the ceiling, moderate reps + heavy weights is best of both worlds | 4-5+ | Allows you to make up the lack of intensity per rep by doing more overall work (moderate intensity) | 0-3 | Best for more "practice," better conditioning, gets more from lighter load, better pump

These ranges are more or less arbitrary. Pick a range that speaks to you, experiment and/ or make up your own

Generally speaking, if you are new, pick the rep ranges that make the most sense

General guidelines: if an exercise involves more muscles, you can go heavier; if less, go lighter

EX: Back squat- sets of 6-12; walking lunges- sets of 8-15; leg curls- sets of 8-30 or 10-20

A good and reliable strategy is to start with a moderately light or moderate rep range, milk out the gains, gradually get heavier, and repeat with heavier weight; vice versa

EX: Back squat- begin with sets of 6-12, then go down to sets of 3-6, then sets of 1-3, and so on; you can also start with heavier loads then lighter

Notes on abs: Do one exercise each day (and pick different variations each day), with two all out sets

When in doubt, just pick "General strength and muscle"

Bodyweight Minimalist Gym Exercises

Squat Patterns | Hinge Patterns | Horizontal Push | Horizontal Pull (Back) | Vertical Push | Vertical Pull | Variations (applies to any exercise)

Bodyweight squat | Single Leg RDL/ SL Banded GM | Deficit Pushup | Inverted Row | Pike Pushup | Feet Assisted Pullup/ Rack Chin | Pauses (top, middle, or bottom)

DB Front Squat | (Single Leg) Hyperextension | Side-Side Pushup | Side-Side Inverted Row | Ring Pike Pushup | Pull/Chin Up | Deeper stretches/ Deficits

Goblet Squat | (Elevated Single Leg) Hip Thrusts | One Arm Pushup | Single Arm Row | Feet Elevated Pike Pushup | Side-Side Pull Up | Slower eccentric

Sumo Squat | Nordic Hip Extension | Decline One Arm Pushup | [blank] | Deficit Handstand Pushup | One Arm Chins | Wider/Closer grip or stance

Advanced Bodyweight Squat Movements | Hinge Accessories (Glutes/Hamstrings) | Chest Continued + Accessories | Back Accessories | Shoulder Accessories | Lat Accessories | Single arm/ leg

Heel Elevated Squat Or Sissy Squats (banded) | Ring Leg Curl | Ring Dip/ RTO Dip | Face Pulls | Face Pulls | Ring Pullover | Weaker angle/ Declines

Walking Lunges/ Reverse Lunges | (Single Leg) Hanging Leg Curl | Bulgarian Dip | Y/T Raises | Y/T Raises | Inverted Ring Low Row | Add bands or Plyos

Bulgarian Split Squats OR Ass to Grass Split Squats | Nordic Curl (Progressions) | Side-Side Ring Dip | Sternum/ BTN Pullup | Inverted Upright Row | Front Lever Pulls | Stricter or Looser form

Above Knee Step Up (Glutes) OR Pistol Squat (Quads) | [blank] | Ring Flies (+Crossovers) | Inverted Shrugs | [blank] | Ring Lat Pull In | Rest Pause

Biceps | Triceps | Abs | Calves | Glute Med (Hips/ "Top shelf") | Obliques | Forearms

Ring Curls | Tricep Pushup | Leg Raises | Donkey Calf Raises | Cossak Squat | Side-Side Leg Raises | Reverse Ring Curls

Pelican Curls | Overhead Tricep Extension (Ring) | Decline Situp | Standing Calf Raise | Lying Side Abduction Hip Thrust | Around the World | False Grip Ring Curls

Single Arm Ring Curls | [blank] | Dragon Flags | Single Leg Calf Raises | Standing Hip Abduction | [blank] | Finger Pushups

[blank] | [blank] | Ab Wheels | [blank] | Frog Hip Thrust | [blank] | Wall Finger Push Offs

[blank] | [blank] | [blank] | [blank] | Deficit Curtsy Lunge | [blank] | Towel PullUp

Program Templates

The 2-3x Week Full Body

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern					
Horizontal push					
Horizontal pull					
Hinge					
Optional acc.					
Optional acc.					
Biceps					
Abs					

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge					
Vertical push					
Vertical pull					
Light squat var.					
Hamstring					
Optional acc.					
Tricep					
Shoulders					
Abs					

Add a third day- A/B/A once you are more advanced
Women can do all leg stuff first before upper body; 2-4 sets lower, 2-3 sets upper
Can split upper body work into separate day

2x Week Sample Women's Program (Lower Body Focus)

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern	Squat	3-4			
Hinge	Good Morning	3-4			
Squat pattern	ATG SS	3-4			
Hinge	Hip Thrust	2-3			
Push	Incline DB Press	2-3			
Pull	Bent Row	2-3			
Bicep	DB Curls	2-3			
Abs	Leg Raises	2-3			

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge	RDL	3-4			
Squat	BSS	3-4			
Ham	Leg Curls	3-4			
Squat	Cossak Squat	3-4			
Push	OHP	2-3			
Pull	Lat Pulldown	2-3			
Shoulder	Face Pull	2-3			
Tricep	French Press	2-3			
Abs	Situps	2-3			

Add a third day- A/B/A if you want a third day

For the third day, you can make a customized training day similar to A

This is an example; make a copy and input your own customized program

Input your own exercises and reps to customize

Add Calf Raises each day for 3/4 sets of 10-15 if desired

If confused by choices of rep ranges, pick a lighter one and less sets

If short on time, do the 1st 4 exercise - then do last 4 next day (Split workouts in half for 4 30 min workouts)

How to save time: pick dumbbell exercises and perform supersets

Q: Why 2-4 sets? A: It comes down to personality and psychological make up. Remember that effort, volume, and frequency has an interrelated and inverse relationship. If you are the type to go all out intense, you'll know and feel that you only need 2 sets. If you know you aren't like that, then you might need extra sets to make up for the lack of intensity. 3 sets is the middle of the road. As long asYou are honest with yourself, you can make the same gains anywhere from 2, 3, or 4 sets.

Sample Women's Program 2-3x Week

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern	Back Squat	3-4	6-12		
Horizontal push	DB Bench Press	3-4	6-12		
Horizontal pull	Chest Supp. Row	3-4	6-12		
Hinge	Backextensions	2-3	8-15		
Optional acc.	Hip Thrust	2-3	8-15		
Optional acc.	Lu Raises	2-3	8-20		
Biceps	DB Curls	2-3	8-20		
Abs	Decline Sit Ups	2-3	8-20		

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge	Romanian Deadlifts	3-4	6-12		
Vertical push	DB Seated OHP	3-4	6-12		
Vertical pull	Lat Pulldowns	3-4	6-12		
Light squat var.	Bulgarian Split Squat	3-4	6-12		
Hinge acc.	Leg Curls	2-3	8-20		
Triceps	French Press	2-3	8-20		
Shoulders	Face Pulls	2-3	8-20		
Abs	Leg Raises	2-3	8-20		

Add a third day- A/B/A if you want a third day

For the third day, you can make a customized training day similar to A

This is an example; make a copy and input your own customized program

Input your own exercises and reps to customize

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Women's Upper Lower 3x Week

Lower 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern	Back Squat				
Hinge Pattern	SL RDL				
Lighter Squat	ATG SS				
Lighter Hinge	Hip Thrust				
Opt. Acc.					
Abs	Leg Raises				

Upper 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push	Incline DB Press	2	6-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Lat Pulldown	2	6-12		
Vert/ Hor Push	Seated DB Press	2	6-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Bent Row	2	6-12		
Opt. Acc.	Pullover	2	6-12		
Tricep	Pushdown	2	6-12		
Bicep	DB Curls	2	6-12		
Shoulder	Y-Raise	2	6-12		
Abs	Situps	2	6-12		

Lower 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge Pattern	RDL				
Squat Pattern	BSS				
Lighter Hinge	Back ext/leg curl				
Lighter Squat	Cossak Squat				
Opt. Acc.					
Abs	Ab Wheel				

NOTES:

When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation OR undulate your volumes

For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow in 1st slot, and do the opposite in the 2nd

The 2nd slots (exercise 3&4) can be done away with, for most effort and intensity on 1st two exercises

If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity (undulate your volumes)

Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry OR what is bolded

Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism

Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required

For a "strength focus", increase intensity, and reduce number of exercises to ~ 6/ workout

Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

2x Week Sample Program (Upper Body Bias)

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Press	Incline Bench				
Hor Pull	Bent Row				
Vert Push	BTN Press				
Squat	Squat				
Ham	Ham Curl				
Shoulders	Lateral Raise				
Biceps	EZ Curl				
Tricep	Skullcrusher				
Abs	Sit ups				

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert push	OHP				
Vert Pull	Feet ass. P.U.				
Chest	Dip/ Flies				
Pull	Chest supp. row				
Hinge	RDL				
Squat	BSS				
Bicep	Incline curl				
Shoulder	Upright Row				

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Tricep	French Press				
Abs	Leg Lifts				

Add a third day- A/B/A once you are more advanced
Input your own exercises and reps to customize (plug and play)
Don't overthink it, just pick something to do and commit

Delan's Program

Upper 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push	Incline press	3-4	RPT		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Chinese Rows	2-3	6-15		
Vert/ Hor Push	BTN Press	2	6-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Pullover	2	6-10		
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep	Pushdowns	2	8-15		
Bicep	DB Curls	2	6-12		
Shoulder	Lateral Raises	2	6-12		
Abs	Decline Situps	2	8-15		

Lower 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern	BSS	2	6-10		
Hinge Pattern	GM	2	6-15		
Lighter Squat	ATG SS	2	8-12		
Lighter Hinge	Ham Curls	2	8-15		
Opt. Acc.	Hip Abduction	2	15-20		
Abs	Hanging side leg raises	2	6-12		

Upper 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push	Handstand PU	3-4	5-15		

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Pull	Pullup	3-4	RPT		
Vert/ Hor Push	Incline flies	2-3	8-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Chest supp. row	2	8-12		
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep	Pushdown	2	8-15		
Bicep	Hammer curl	2	6-12		
Shoulder	Upright row	2	8-15		
Abs	Dragon flag	2	8-15		

Lower 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge Pattern	Deficit RDL	2-3	6-12		
Squat Pattern	Pistol squat	2	8-12		
Lighter Hinge	Jefferson curl	2	8-12		
Lighter Squat	Cossak squat	2	8-10		
Opt. Acc.	Hip abduction	2	15-20		
Abs	Russian twist	2	10-15		

NOTES:

The four days/ week over 2 or 3 days is simply on personal preference; the same program can either be shrunken down to 2x/ week OR expanded into 6x/week depending on your temperament and goals

This routine is not static; I always keep the same structure, but I will switch out different exercises of the same category when I get bored, plateau, or change goals

The movements in this template are simply a reflection of my personal goals: to look and perform like a superhero:

To drive up strength, to develop powerful shoulders, thick and wide upper back, chiseled upper chest, and legs like bronze

Again, the template always stays the same, but I am constantly rotating out different exercises

Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Delan's Program V.2 (3x Week)

Upper 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push	Incline press	3-4	RPT		

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Pull	Chinese Rows	2-3	6-15		
Vert/ Hor Push	BTN Press	2	6-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Pullover	2	6-10		
Opt. Acc.	Flies/ dips	2	6-12		
Tricep	Pushdowns	2	8-15		
Bicep	DB Curls	2	6-12		
Shoulder	Lateral Raises	2	6-12		
Abs	Decline Situps	2	8-15		

Lower 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern	Platz squat	2	6-10		
Hinge Pattern	Def. SLDL	2	6-15		
Lighter Squat	BSS	2	8-12		
Lighter Hinge	SL RDL	2	8-15		
Quad	Pistol squat	2	15-20		
Hinge	Leg curls	2	6-12		
Opt. Acc.	Hip abd.				
Abs	Side bends				

Upper 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push	OHP	3-4	5-15		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Pullup	3-4	RPT		
Vert/ Hor Push	Incline flies	2-3	8-12		
Vert/ Hor Pull	Chest supp. row	2	8-12		
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep	French press	2	8-15		
Bicep	Incline curl	2	6-12		
Shoulder	Upright row	2	8-15		
Abs	Dragon flag	2	8-15		

NOTES:

The four days/ week over 2 or 3 days is simply on personal preference; the same program can either be shrunken down to 2x/ week OR expanded into 6x/week depending on your temperament and goals

This routine is not static; I always keep the same structure, but I will switch out different exercises of the same category when I get bored, plateau, or change goals

The movements in this template are simply a reflection of my personal goals: to look and perform like a superhero:

To drive up strength, to develop powerful shoulders, thick and wide upper back, chiseled upper chest, and legs like bronze

Again, the template always stays the same, but I am constantly rotating out different exercises

Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Advanced 3x Week Program

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern					
Hor/Vert Push					
Hor/ Vert Pull					
Hinge					
Shoulders/ Traps					
Triceps					
Biceps					
Opt. Acc.					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Light squat var.					
Hinge Var.					
Triceps					
Biceps					
Shoulders/ Traps					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Workout C

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Hinge Var.					
Shoulder/ Traps					
Triceps					
Biceps					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

NOTES:
When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

3x Week Minimalist Program

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Incline Bench					
Klokov Press					
Weighted Pull Up					
Squat					
Bicep					
Shoulders					
Abs					

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Weighted Dips					
RDL					
Rows					
Shoulders					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Abs					

Workout C

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
OHP					
Pull Up Var.					
Single Leg					
Leg Curls					
Tricep					
Shoulders					
Abs					

NOTES:
Do the leg movements first if lower body is your main goal
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Generic 3x Week Minimalist Program

Workout A

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat					
Hor. Press					
Hor. Pull					
HInge					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Bicep					
Shoulders					
Abs					

Workout B

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
HInge					
Vert. Press					
Vert. Pull					
Light Squat					
Shoulders					
Tricep					
Abs					

Workout C

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat					
Press					
Pull					
Hinge					
Accessory					
Shoulders					
Abs					

NOTES:
Do the leg movements first if lower body is your main goal
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Chest + Arms / Legs / Back + Shoulders

Chest + Arms

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Incline Bench					
Weighted Dips					
Incline Flies					
Tricep Iso					
Bicep					
Abs					

Legs

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Var.					
Hinge					
Light Squat					
Light Hinge					
Calves					
Abs					

Back + Shoulders

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
OHP					
Pull Up Var.					
BTN Press					
Rows					
Shoulder Iso					
Opt. Front Raise					
Abs					

NOTES:
Do the leg movements first if lower body is your main goal
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Upper Lower 3x Week

Upper 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep					
Bicep					
Shoulder					
Abs					

Lower 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern					
Hinge Pattern					
Lighter Squat					
Lighter Hinge					
Opt. Acc.					
Opt. Acc.					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Upper 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep					
Bicep					
Shoulder					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Abs					

NOTES:

When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation OR undulate your volumes

For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow in 1st slot, and do the opposite in the 2nd

The 2nd slots (exercise 3&4) can be done away with, for most effort and intensity on 1st two exercises

If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity (undulate your volumes)

Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry OR what is bolded

Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism

Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required

For a "strength focus", increase intensity, and reduce number of exercises to ~ 6/ workout

Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Upper Lower 4x Week

Upper 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep					
Bicep					
Shoulder					
Abs					

Lower 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Pattern					
Hinge Pattern					
Lighter Squat					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Lighter Hinge					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Upper 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Vert/ Hor Push					
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Tricep					
Bicep					
Shoulder					
Abs					

Lower 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hinge Pattern					
Squat Pattern					
Lighter Hinge					
Lighter Squat					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

NOTES:

When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation OR undulate your volumes

For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow in 1st slot, and do the opposite in the 2nd

The 2nd slots (exercise 3&4) can be done away with, for most effort and intensity on 1st two exercises

If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity (undulate your volumes)

Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry OR what is bolded

Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism

Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
For a "strength focus", increase intensity, and reduce number of exercises to ~ 6/ workout
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

The Intelligent Bro 5x Week

Chest

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Main Press					
Second Press					
Opt. Movement					
Opt. Movement					
Abs					

Back

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert/ Hor Pull					
Hor/ Vert Pull					
Back Isolation					
Opt. Back Iso.					
Abs					

Shoulders

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Vert Press					
Shoulder					
Shoulder					
Shoulder					
Abs					

Arms

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Bicep					
Tricep					
Bicep					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Tricep					
Abs					

Legs

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat pattern					
Hinge					
Lighter Squat					
Lighter Hinge					
Optional acc.					
Optional acc.					
Abs					

NOTES:
When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation
For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Separate "Sharms" (Shoulder and arms) if desired for gym frequency and efficiency
Rearrange "Sharms" for your personal goals (i.e. work the muscle you care more about 1st)
For a "strength focus", increase intensity, and reduce number of exercises to ~ 6/ workout
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

Torso + Sharms + Legs 6x Week

Torso 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Main Press					
Main Pull					
Lighter Press					
Lighter Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Opt. Acc.					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Abs					

Sharms 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Main Press					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Shoulder					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Abs					

Legs 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat					
Hinge					
Light Squat					
Light Hinge					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Torso 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Main Press					
Main Pull					
Lighter Press					
Lighter Pull					
Opt. Acc.					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

Sharms 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Main Press					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Shoulder					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Abs					

Legs 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat					
Hinge					
Light Squat					
Light Hinge					
Opt. Acc.					
Abs					

NOTES:
When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation
For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Use the first 4 exercises if in a hurry
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
Separate "Sharms" (Shoulder and arms) if desired for gym frequency and efficiency
Rearrange "Sharms" for your personal goals (i.e. work the muscle you care more about 1st)
For a "strength focus", increase intensity, and reduce number of exercises to ~ 6/ workout
Throw in neck, calves, and forearms at the end if desired (or pick movements that bias them)

The Daily 15-30

Day 1

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Hor Press					
Hor Pull					

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Opt. Curls					
Abs					

Day 2

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Squat Var.					
Light Hinge					
Opt. Calves					
Abs					

Day 3

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
OHP Var.					
Dips					
Abs					

Day 4

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Pull Ups					
Shoulder					
Opt. Pullovers					
Abs					

Day 5

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Heavy Hinge					
Lighter Squat					
Opt. Ham Curl					
Abs					

Day 6

Movement	Exercise	Sets	Reps	Weight	Notes
Lighter Press					
Bicep					
Tricep					
Abs					

NOTES:
When working on the same movement pattern in the week, perform a different variation
For Vert/ Hor, prioritize the movement pattern/ muscle groups you wish to grow
If you wish to perform the same variation, pick a different rep range and intensity
Do not neglect explosive, power, or calisthenic movements for athleticism
Optional accessories are for extra work where needed or desired, but is not required
For more time efficiency, use primarily dumbbells and (weighted) bodyweight movements
Abs are optional